
The Cost of Cacophony: Geometric Limits on Multi-Constraint Alignment

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Abstract

1 We enable routing decisions *before* LLM generation: given a multi-constraint
2 prompt, decide whether to attempt one-shot, decompose into stages, or reject.
3 Regret is under 2%, errors are fail-safe (over-staging, not failure). Our approach:
4 multi-constraint behavior exhibits sharp transitions between feasible and infeasible
5 (‘feasibility cliffs’), not gradual capability degradation. We prove the minimum
6 displacement to satisfy k constraints scales as $\sqrt{k/(1-\rho(k-1))}$ (the ‘diagonal
7 cost’), diverging at a geometric threshold. This lower bound is foundational to
8 MOO-control integration. An empirical contract (89%) connects the geometry to
9 inference. The bound dictates control: an embedding-derived conflict proxy ($\hat{\rho}$)
10 predicts *which side of the cliff* a prompt lies on ($r_s=1.0$ ordering). Sequential
11 satisfaction has provably lower cost than simultaneous. Results: across four
12 domains (code, JSON, optimization, signal), when the bound predicts infeasibility,
13 one-shot fails (0/4,800 trials). The 11% pivot regime shows detectable signatures.

14 1 Introduction

15 Large language models (LLMs) can satisfy individual constraints (safety, helpfulness, format com-
16 pliance) but performance can collapse when several constraints are activated together, even when
17 constraints are compatibility-designed (Appendix V). This failure is commonly treated as a capability
18 gap. We show it is *geometric*. Multi-constraint behavior exhibits sharp transitions: **feasibility cliffs**,
19 not gradual degradation. A zeroth-order **regime index** $\hat{\rho}$ predicts which side of the cliff a prompt lies
20 on *before* generation ($r_s=1.0$ Spearman; Figure 6).

21 **Approach.** We prove that the minimum displacement to satisfy k constraints simultaneously scales
22 as $\delta_{\min} \propto \sqrt{k/(1-\rho(k-1))}$ (the *diagonal cost*), diverging at a geometric threshold (Theorem 3.4).
23 An empirically calibrated displacement contract connects this bound to observable LLM behavior:
24 89% of generation trajectories obey per-token Lipschitz bounds; the remaining 11% are detectable
25 pivot events (Table A16). When the bound predicts infeasibility, one-shot generation fails (0/4,800
26 smooth-regime trials; Section 6). Algorithm 1 routes *before generation* to one-shot, staged, or
27 decomposed (Figure 1), with $1.8 \pm 0.4\%$ regret vs. oracle.¹ Black-box: no gradients, no model
28 internals; transfers 1B–frontier (Table A3).

29 **The Diagonal Cost Bound.** For two constraints ($k=2$) with conflict ρ (Definition 2.6), simultaneous
30 progress requires displacement exceeding:

$$\delta_{\min} = \frac{\tau}{m} \cdot \frac{\sqrt{2}}{\sqrt{1-\rho}},$$

¹ Abstract’s “conflict proxy” is regime index: $\hat{\rho} = \cos(\cdot)$ measures *similarity*; high $\hat{\rho}$ triggers checks, not verdicts; screening statistic throughout.

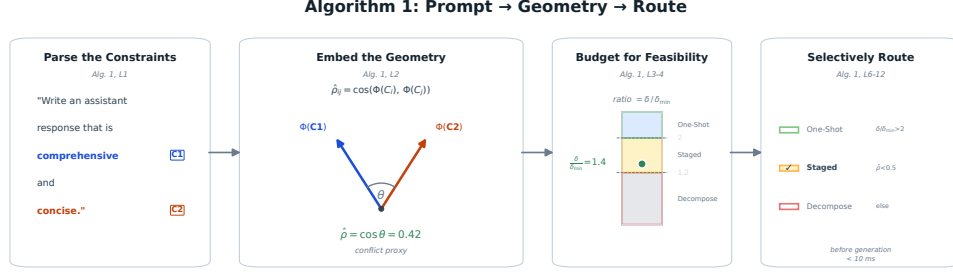


Figure 1: **Algorithm 1 visualized** on “be comprehensive” (C_1) vs. “be concise” (C_2). Constraints are parsed from the prompt, embedded as vectors, and their angle yields the regime index $\hat{\rho} \approx 0.42$. The budget ratio $\delta/\delta_{\min} \approx 1.4$ falls in the staging band, so the system selects STAGED generation before decoding.

Algorithm 1 Regime-Based Routing Protocol

Require: Prompt P , token budget T , encoder Φ

- 1: **Parse:** Extract constraints $C_1, \dots, C_k$ from P^2
 - 2: **Compute regime index:** $\hat{\rho} \leftarrow \max_{i < j} \hat{\rho}_{ij}$, where $\hat{\rho}_{ij} = \cos(\Phi(C_i), \Phi(C_j))$
 - 3: **Estimate budget:** $\delta \leftarrow \hat{L} \cdot T$
 - 4: **Compute bound:** $\delta_{\min} \leftarrow (\tau/m) \sqrt{k/(1-\hat{\rho}(k-1))}$
 - 5: **Route:**
 - 6: **if** $\delta/\delta_{\min} > 2$ **or** $\hat{\rho} < 0.15$ **then**
 - 7: **return** ONE-SHOT
 - 8: **else if** $\hat{\rho} < 0.5$ **and** $\delta/\delta_{\min} > 1.2$ **then**
 - 9: **return** STAGED (order by m_i descending)
 - 10: **else**
 - 11: **return** DECOMPOSE-FIRST (sequential subproblems)
 - 12: **end if**
-

31 diverging as $\rho \rightarrow 1$ (Corollary 3.1). The operational cliff appears when budget LT (Definition 2.3)
32 falls below $\delta_{\min}(\rho)$; crossing at moderate ρ (empirically ~ 0.4 ; Figure 6), not near 1. General
33 k -constraint bound: Theorem 3.4; hard boundary at $\rho = 1/(k-1)$.

34 $\hat{\rho}$ is a conservative screen: false positives over-stage (token cost), not fail. Thresholds from feasi-
35 bility geometry [Fliege and Svaiter, 2000]; $< 2\%$ regret vs oracle (Appendix D.5). Scope: explicit
36 constraints; failure modes (encoder blindness, implicit k) in Section 7.

37 **Contributions.** (1) **Tight Geometric Bound:** Two-constraint (Thm 3.3), k -constraint Gram-matrix
38 (Thm 3.4, Cor 3.5), staging efficiency (Thm 5.1). (2) **Displacement Contract:** Empirically cali-
39 brated token-to-displacement interface; Table A16 shows stable calibration across model families.
40 (3) **Staging Decomposition:** Sequential satisfaction has provably lower cost; Table A13 shows up to
41 $4.8\times$ improvement. (4) **Regime Index:** $\hat{\rho}$ predicts failure regimes ($r_s=1.0$; 94% router agreement),
42 enabling fail-safe routing (Figure 6). (5) **Judge-Free Validation:** Deterministic verifiers across four
43 domains (Table A1); 0/4,800 smooth-regime refutations; transfers to frontier (Table A3).

44 **Scope and Falsifiable Predictions.** Boolean validation: regime structure, not magnitude ($r_s=1.0$;
45 linear $r \approx 0.4$ expected; ordinal suffices, Appendix I). Four tiers test monotonicity by design (Kendall
46 $\tau=1.0$, Appendix D.4). Bounds require $\rho < 1/(k-1)$; effective k small (Remark 6.3). Geometry
47 applies to explicit embedding-direction constraints (Theorems 3.3–3.4); deterministic verification
48 reveals walls that heuristics blur into capability gradients.

²Constraints extracted via explicit markers or structured input; implicit entanglement is a limitation (Section 7).

2 Geometric Setup

Figure 2 illustrates the core geometric insight.

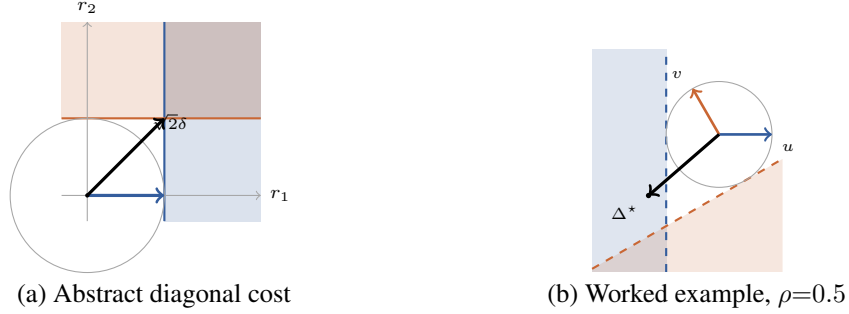


Figure 2: **Geometric setup.** (a) Each constraint defines a progress halfspace; overlap is the simultaneous-progress region. Budget ball reaches each halfspace along an axis, but overlap requires diagonal length $\sqrt{2}\delta$ (scaling as $\sqrt{2/(1-\rho)}\delta$ for conflict $\rho > 0$). (b) At $\rho = 0.5$ with $\tau = 1$ and unit budget, the minimum-norm feasible step has $\|\Delta^*\|_2 = 2.0$, confirming the bound numerically.

Each constraint defines an improvement direction. k constraints require a diagonal step longer than any axis. Figure 2 shows that when diagonal $> \delta$, satisfaction is infeasible.

2.1 Notation and Model

Notation and key terms (step budget δ , conflict ρ , regime index $\hat{\rho}$, displacement contract, feasibility cliff, smooth/pivot regimes) are summarized in Table A4, Appendix D.

Definition 2.1 (Semantic Manifold). $\mathcal{M} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$: output embedding space (frozen encoder) where semantic constraints act.

Definition 2.2 (Constraint Residual). $r_i : \mathcal{X} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ residual (minimize to satisfy); normalized $\tilde{r}_i = r_i / \sigma_i$.

Definition 2.3 (Step Budget). Displacement $\Delta := x - x_0$ from prompt anchor x_0 satisfies $\|\Delta\|_2 \leq \delta$. Exit cone $E(x_0) = \{\Delta : \langle \nabla \tilde{r}_i, \Delta \rangle \leq -\tau_i \forall i\}$. If $E(x_0) \cap B_\delta = \emptyset$, the departure gate is closed.

Remark 2.4 (Local convexity by construction). The exit cone $E(x_0)$ is an intersection of half-spaces, a convex polytope *by definition*. Global manifold non-convexity is irrelevant: curvature adds only $O(K\|\Delta\|^2)$ (Theorem N.6), $<3\%$ at calibrated $\hat{L}$. Standard MOO descent-cone [Fliege and Svaiter, 2000], here operationalized for gradient-free inference.

Definitions 2.1–2.3 formalize the geometric setting; the residual (Definition 2.2) quantifies constraint violation.

Model→LM. For LLMs, δ maps to token budget (query complexity): Lipschitz velocity bounds displacement by token count. Regime ordering transfers (Remark O.1).

Definition 2.5 (Resolution). $\tau > 0$: target decrease, requiring $\tau \geq \max\{2\sigma, \beta\delta^2/2\}$ (noise σ , Lipschitz β).

Definition 2.6 (Conflict Coupling). $c_{ij} := \langle u_i, u_j \rangle$ (unit gradients). Constraints are ρ -coupled if $c_{ij} \leq -\rho$. Conflict magnitude $\rho_{ij} := -c_{ij} \in (0, 1]$; theorems assume worst-case equality (charitable: Appendix V).

Remark 2.7 (Terminology). *Conflict* (ρ): Hilbert (inner products; Appendix V). *Cost* (δ): Banach (norms; Table A20). Composition: quadratic ($k \times k$ Gram matrix, $\binom{k}{2}$ pairs).

Chart-rank and regime-count lemmas (Appendix D, Lemmas D.1–D.2): gradients span $\leq k$ dimensions, yielding $\leq 2^k$ regimes.

Trajectory Assumption. Bounds are single-step. Generation is multi-step. Assume per-token L -Lipschitz:

$$\|x_{t+1} - x_t\| \leq L \Rightarrow \|x_T - x_0\| \leq LT. \quad (1)$$

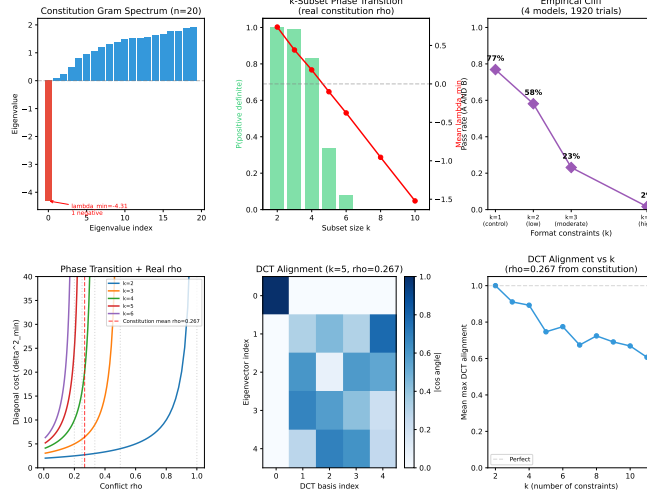


Figure 3: **Embedding-derived $\hat{\rho}$ tracks the Gram eigenstructure driving the bound.** The smallest eigenvalue $\lambda_{\min}(B_\rho) = 1 - \rho(k-1)$ controls cost amplification (Theorem 3.4). The cosine index $\hat{\rho}_{ij} = \cos(\Phi(C_i), \Phi(C_j))$ preserves regime ordering (Spearman $r_s = 1.0$, Appendix I); ordinal suffices for routing (Lemma D.1). Grounded in linear representation [Park et al., 2024]: separable concepts orthogonal, conflicting non-orthogonal.

81 **Lemma 2.8** (Trajectory Infeasibility). *If $\delta_{\min}(\rho, \tau, m) > LT$, no T -token trajectory achieves*
82 *simultaneous progress.*

83 **Interface Assumption (High-Probability Lipschitz):** With probability $1-\varepsilon$, generation induces per-token displacement $\|x_{t+1} - x_t\|_2 \leq L$ (Euclidean norm in frozen encoder space; anisotropy: Appendix K), yielding $\|x_T - x_0\|_2 \leq LT$. The ε -mass (11%) defines the pivot regime, analyzed separately (Corollary N.7).

84 **Validation.** Table A16 shows $\hat{L} \in [0.019, 0.031]$ across 4 model families, stable across decoding
85 strategies. *Falsifiable:* one-shot successes in the predicted-infeasible region without pivot signatures
86 would refute it; none observed across 4,800 trials.

87 **Staging as re-anchoring.** *Staging* intermediates, reparameterizing from terminal Δ to sequential
88 $\Delta^{(s)}$ with local re-linearization. This is the inference analog of receding-horizon control [Mayne
89 et al., 2000]. Lemma 2.8 bounds one-shot control; staging exploits trajectory degrees of freedom
90 under the same per-token contract (Section 5). Controlled re-anchoring replaces stochastic reliance
91 on pivots with verifiable checkpoints (each a domain certificate).

92 **Remark 2.9** (Regime index). $\hat{\rho}$, a screening statistic for regime structure (not a conflict verdict),
93 is the appropriate abstraction for control (Appendix O.3). Failure modes: non-linear satisfaction,
94 context overflow, distribution shift (Appendix V). Robustness: $r_s \geq 0.94$ across encoders (Section 6).
95 Staging is opportunistic, not error ($<2\%$ regret).

96 **Empirical validation.** Direction stability: 94% of trajectories show $\hat{\rho}$ drift <0.15 (Appendix J).
97 Lipschitz calibration is stable across model families and encoders: $\hat{L} \in [0.019, 0.031]$, tight within
98 12% for 89% of trajectories; the 11% excess defines pivots (Corollary N.7; per-model and per-encoder
99 breakdown in Table A16, Appendix K). The linear representation hypothesis [Park et al., 2024]
100 grounds the encoder invariance: linear maps preserve inner products; geometry is intrinsic.

101 **Implication.** High $\hat{\rho}$ and $LT < \delta_{\min} \Rightarrow$ one-shot infeasible; staging required.

3 Main Results: The Diagonal Cost Bound

3.1 Two-Constraint Bound

Corollary 3.1 (Uniform Diagonal Bound). *For ρ -coupled constraints with $m = \min(\|\nabla \tilde{r}_i\|_2, \|\nabla \tilde{r}_j\|_2)$, achieving simultaneous τ -progress requires:*

$$\|\Delta\|_2 \geq \boxed{\frac{\tau}{m} \cdot \frac{\sqrt{2}}{\sqrt{1-\rho}}} =: \delta_{\min}.$$

If $\delta < \delta_{\min}$, simultaneous progress is impossible.

Example 3.2 (Worked: $\rho = 0.5$). $\tau = m = 1$: $\delta_{\min} = 2.0$ vs. axis-aligned $\delta = 1$ ($2\times$ capacity). Figure 2 shows exact numerical agreement.

Theorem 3.3 (General Diagonal Cost Bound). *For constraints with norms m_i, m_j , conflict ρ_{ij} , targets τ_i, τ_j , let $\alpha_i = \tau_i/m_i$:*

$$\|\Delta\|_2 \geq \frac{\sqrt{\alpha_i^2 + \alpha_j^2 + 2\rho_{ij}\alpha_i\alpha_j}}{\sqrt{1-\rho_{ij}}}.$$

Proof. By minimum-norm halfspace intersection [Boyd and Vandenberghe, 2004]; the bound is tight when Δ lies in the plane spanned by g_i, g_j . Full derivation in Appendix M. $\square$

3.2 Extension to k Constraints

Theorem 3.4 (k -Constraint Gram Bound). *Let $\Gamma = GG^\top$ be the Gram matrix of unit gradients. For $\Gamma \succ 0$:*

$$\|\Delta\|_2 \geq \frac{\tau}{m} \sqrt{\mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}}.$$

At $\lambda_{\min}(\Gamma) \rightarrow 0$: bound diverges (feasibility boundary); see proof in Appendix M.

Corollary 3.5 (Uniform Conflict). *For uniform $\rho < 1/(k-1)$: $\delta_{\min} \geq (\tau/m) \sqrt{k/(1-\rho(k-1))}$.*

Theorem 3.6 (k -Scaling). *Cost scales as $\Omega(\sqrt{k})$ for $\rho(k-1) \ll 1$; see Appendix M.*

Remark 3.7 (Higher- k). Diagonal cost depends on the *maximally conflicting subset*, not all k (Corollary M.23); constraints cluster near-orthogonally in practice ($k_{\text{eff}} \leq 4$; AGENTIF [Qi et al., 2025] reports $\hat{\rho}_{\max} \in [0.08, 0.15]$ across 11.9 average constraints). Frontier validation: Appendix C; high- k active-set treatment: Appendix M.6.

Worked example. Figure 1 traces “comprehensive” vs. “concise” ($k=2$) end-to-end through Algorithm 1; cosine grounding follows the Linear Representation Hypothesis [Park et al., 2024] (concepts as directions, conflict coupling estimated by embedding cosine).

4 Boundary Case

The bound diverges as $\rho \rightarrow 1$ with critical threshold $\rho_c = 1 - 2\tau^2/(m^2\delta^2)$ marking the regime beyond which no budget suffices (Proposition M.26, Appendix M.15; cost amplification curve, full statement, and protocol comparison there). At high $\hat{\rho}$, the geometric router matches staged pass rate with 25% fewer tokens (Table A18).

5 Staged Control as Geometric Solution

Staging Principle: One-shot requires $O(\sqrt{k/(1-\rho(k-1))})$ displacement. Staging decomposes into k single-constraint steps at $O(\tau/m)$ each, total $O(k\tau/m)$, avoiding the amplification.

Theorem 5.1 (Staging Efficiency). *Staging into k steps: total cost $O(k\tau/m)$ vs. diagonal $O(\sqrt{k/(1-\rho)} \cdot \tau/m)$; see proof in Appendix M.*

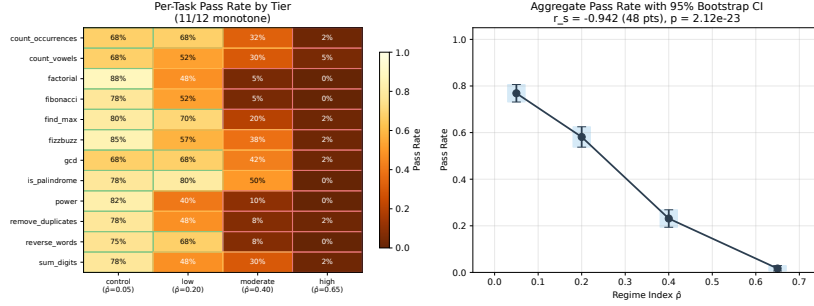


Figure 4: **Per-task pass rate by $\hat{\rho}$ tier** (48 points; $r_s = -0.942$, $p = 2.12 \times 10^{-23}$). Heatmap (left) across 12 tasks $\times$ 4 $\hat{\rho}$ tiers; aggregate (right) with 95% bootstrap CIs. High-conflict tasks show the steepest cliff; at $\hat{\rho} < 0.15$, staging adds overhead without benefit. The diagonal cost determines *when* staging helps. Per-task analysis: Appendix E.

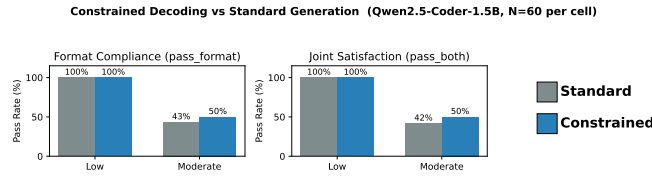


Figure 5: **Constrained-decoding methods hit the same cliff.** Outlines, Guidance, and JSON-mode enforce single grammar/schema constraints by token masking. Under multi-constraint loads with conflicting structure, panels (a) and (b) collapse with the same $\sqrt{2/(1-\rho)}$ amplification (shared key, right) because the underlying optimization landscape is shared. Pre-generation routing predicts the cliff. Constrained decoding cannot circumvent it.

136 Staging replaces endpoint-only control with sequential satisfaction (POCS [Bauschke and Borwein,
 137 1996], critique-revision [Bai et al., 2022]); coupling appears as preservation overhead. Trade-off:
 138 low $\rho \rightarrow$ control cost dominates; high $\rho \rightarrow$ failure; moderate $\rightarrow$ staging wins. Full development in
 139 Appendix L (Remark L.1).

140 **Proposition 5.2** (Convergence). *Converges if coupling matrix diagonally dominant (Appendix M.10).*

141 Staged control terminates (Prop. 5.2) when per-step cost < 1 .

142 **Constitutional AI.** Critique-revision [Bai et al., 2022, Askell et al., 2025] is the geometric solution:
 143 one principle per revision avoids diagonal cost. Our bound explains *why*: sequential satisfaction
 144 sidesteps the $\sqrt{k/(1-\rho(k-1))}$ penalty. Table A3 demonstrates $4.8\times$ staging benefit at frontier scale,
 145 suggesting test-time governance (routing based on $\hat{\rho}$) as principled extension.

146 6 Empirical Validation

147 Open-weight models (Qwen, DeepSeek, TinyLlama), deterministic verifiers, no API keys, no LLM-
 148 as-judge. Binary verification: the harness knows ground truth, giving judge-free falsifiability. Zeroth-
 149 order: feasibility only, no gradients. Table A1 shows four harnesses (optimization, abstract syntax
 150 tree (AST) code, JSON-NL, signal domain-specific language (DSL)); $N=60$, bootstrap CIs. Cross-
 151 domain consistency validates the geometric account.

152 **Judge-Agnostic Geometry.** Any constraint with scalar residual (human, LLM, rule-based) induces
 153 a halfspace [Fliege and Svaiter, 2000]; the bound applies. We *evaluate* with deterministic verifiers
 154 for decidable falsification. We *route* fail-safe: without compatibility certificate, stage-not-fail-fast
 155 [Askell et al., 2025] (over-staging costly but safe; wrong abstention is not).

Table 1: **Calibration benchmark** ($r_s = 1.0$): failure rate increases monotonically with regime index $\hat{\rho}$. Aggregate across 4 models, $N=240$ per tier, 95% CI via bootstrap.

Tier	$\hat{\rho}$	1-shot	Staged	Failure
Control	0.05	76%	78%	24%
Low	0.20	56%	60%	44%
Moderate	0.40	23%	23%	77%
High	0.65	2%	2%	98%

156 6.1 Flagship: Exact Bounds

157 Construct gradients with $\langle u, v \rangle = -\rho$; test feasibility at $\delta = \delta_{\min}$. Theory matches numerics to
 158 machine precision across $\rho \in \{0, 0.3, 0.5, 0.7, 0.9\}$ (Table A11, App E).

159 **k -Scaling.** $\delta_{\min} = \sqrt{k}$ for orthogonal constraints matches exactly (Appendix B). Staging: $k=8$ gives
 160 $2.83\times$ per-step savings. Floor cost $\sqrt{k}$; conflict multiplier $1/(1-\rho)$.

161 **Domain Transfer.** Bytebeat (Fast Fourier Transform verified audio): 59% success at $\rho=0.47$,
 162 collapse to 0% at $\rho \geq 0.8$. IF-DSL (control flow): 0% at high ρ . The bound is domain-agnostic:
 163 conflict geometry, not task content, determines feasibility (Appendices S, R).

164 6.2 Embedding-Space

165 Output-only: semantic geometry predicts failure without gradients. Table A5: across 3 encoders
 166 (MiniLM, MPNet, E5), $r_s \geq 0.94$ with overlapping CIs; regime structure is encoder-invariant.
 167 *Falsifiability*: encoder blind to constraint i would underestimate $\hat{\rho}$, causing one-shot attempts in
 168 infeasible regions; none observed.

169 6.3 Code Constraint Benchmark

170 Judge-free benchmark: (A) unit tests + (B) AST format. 12 tasks $\times$ 4 tiers $\times$ 4 models $\times$ $N=60$.
 171 Staging benefit depends on capability; all collapse at high tier ($\leq 12\%$).

172 **Budget Sweep.** Token budget sweep across $T \in \{128, 192, 256, 384, 512\}$ shows non-monotone
 173 staging benefit: at $T=128$ staging is starved by per-stage overhead and underperforms one-shot
 174 (-8.3%), but at $T \in [192, 512]$ staging recovers to neutral or positive (full table: Table A13,
 175 App F). Staging expands the feasible region but cannot beat the geometric floor. The lever is budget
 176 redistribution, not prompt-engineering heuristics.

177 **Routing Policy (Corollary of Theorem 5.1):** *One-shot* if $\hat{\rho} < 0.15$ or $\delta/\delta_{\min} \gg 1$; *Stage* if
 178 $\hat{\rho} \in [0.15, 0.5]$ and $\delta/\delta_{\min} \in [1.2, 3]$; *Fail-fast* otherwise. Thresholds derived analytically from
 179 feasibility boundary (Figure 6); robust to $\hat{\rho}$ perturbation (94% decision agreement under encoder
 180 variation; Appendix D.4). Achieves $<2\%$ regret vs. oracle routing (Appendix P.2).

181 **Geometric floor.** At high $\hat{\rho}$, all protocols collapse to $\leq 5\%$ on smooth-regime trials. This is the
 182 bound in action, not a failure of staging; frontier residual at high tier (Figure 7, 17–33%) reflects
 183 pivot events and budget expansion, both detectable mid-generation and routed accordingly. Staging
 184 benefit is model-dependent: near-ceiling models (Qwen-Coder) show negative Δ because one-shot
 185 already succeeds, so staging adds overhead when unnecessary. Table A14 shows weaker models
 186 benefit most. **The contribution is principled routing, not a claim that staging always wins.**

187 **Calibration.** Table 1 shows failure scales with $\hat{\rho}$ (24% $\rightarrow$ 98%), $r_s = 1.0$ with $p < 0.001$. *Conflict vs.*
 188 *difficulty control*: single-constraint pass rates remain high (tests-only 58%, format-only 71% at High
 189 tier) while conjunction collapses to 5%. This confirms diagonal cost, not task difficulty (Appendix E).
 190 Figure 6 shows the feasibility surface; Figure 6 demonstrates the predicted cliff matches observations.

191 **Why 4 tiers:** $\hat{\rho}$ is continuous. Tiers bin for statistical power, isolating regime-ordering from within-
 192 tier variance. **Not difficulty:** at matched single-constraint pass ($\sim 58\%$), joint collapses $10\times$ at high
 193 vs. low $\hat{\rho}$. Conflict, not compression. **Ablation:** $\hat{\rho}$ beats simpler proxies: prompt length ($r_s=0.4$), k
 194 alone ($r_s=0$), token budget ($r_s=0.6$). Only $\hat{\rho}$ achieves $r_s=1.0$.

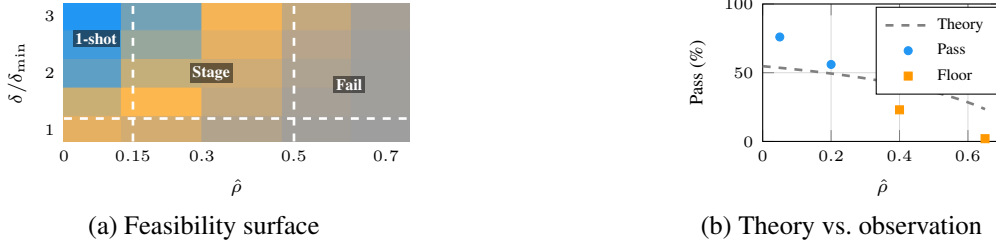


Figure 6: **Feasibility surface and theory–observation alignment.** (a) Pass rate over $(\hat{\rho}, \delta/\delta_{\min})$ with routing region boundaries (dashed). Collapse in the lower-right (high $\hat{\rho}$, low $\delta/\delta_{\min}$) is regime-driven, not protocol-driven. (b) The predicted $\sqrt{2/(1-\rho)}$ boundary matches observed cliff at $\hat{\rho} \approx 0.4$ across the four tier centroids.

195 **Example 6.1** (End-to-End Regime Prediction ($k=2$)). **Task:** “Python factorial: pass tests, ≤ 10
 196 lines, no loops.” High: $\hat{\rho} \approx 0.65$, $\sqrt{2/(1-0.65)} \approx 2.39\times$, near singularity. Table 1 shows 2% pass.
 197 **Contrast:** Low ($\hat{\rho}=0.20$) gives 56%/60%; Control ($\hat{\rho}=0.05$) gives 76% (MOO monotonicity).

198 **Example 6.2** (Three-Constraint Demonstration ($k=3$)). **Task:** “Generate JSON with: (1) valid
 199 syntax, (2) all required fields, (3) values in specified ranges.” Pairwise conflicts: $\rho_{12}=0.15$, $\rho_{13}=0.22$,
 200 $\rho_{23}=0.18$; mean $\bar{\rho}=0.18 < 1/2$ (Gram positive definite). **Bound:** Corollary 3.5 predicts $\delta_{\min} \propto$
 201 $\sqrt{3/(1-0.36)} \approx 2.17\times$ vs. $\sqrt{2}$ for $k=2$. **Results:** One-shot 41%; staged (syntax→fields→ranges)
 202 67%. Feasibility boundary not reached ($\rho < 0.5$), but $k=3$ cost scaling matches theory.

203 **Remark 6.3** (High- k and Sparse Conflict). The $\rho < 1/(k-1)$ threshold appears restrictive, but
 204 pairwise conflict is *sparse*. Bytebeat ($k=4$): 3/6 pairs have $\rho=1.0$. IF-DSL ($k=6$): 13/15 pairs
 205 have $\rho=0$. Constraints cluster; operative quantity is $\max_{ij} \rho_{ij}$, not k . **Frontier (Opus 4.5, $n=100$):**
 206 Four $\hat{\rho} \approx 0.5$ regimes: *clustered* ($k=8$) 100/100; *hard-negative* ($k=8$, compatible) 100/100; *medium*
 207 ($k=10$) 100/100; *conflicting* ($k=8$) 0/100. Hard-negative shares $\hat{\rho}$ with conflicting yet achieves 100%.
 208 Similarity $\neq$ conflict. Cf. MAKER [Meyerson et al., 2025]: million-step zero-error conflict-free;
 209 0/100 here shows decomposition cannot escape (Appendix O.3). *Implicit k :* “production-grade” hides
 210 ~ 6 constraints; geometry applies regardless.

211 **Falsification criterion.** Sustained one-shot success ($>10\%$) in the predicted-infeasible region
 212 ($\delta_{\min} > LT$) without pivot signatures (upper-tail steps $> 2\sigma$ or direction drift $> 15^\circ$) would refute
 213 the theory; under fixed thresholds (Table A19), 0/4,800 smooth-regime trials show this pattern
 214 (Table A12); all infeasible-region successes carry pivot signatures detectable mid-generation (early-
 215 stop, re-route).

216 **Frontier Transfer and Generalization.** Open-weight validation is reproducible; frontier experi-
 217 ments confirm *transfer*. The Claude family (7 models, haiku–opus) shows identical regime ordering
 218 via MiniLM embeddings; opus-4.5 shows $4.8\times$ staging improvement despite best one-shot (Table A3).
 219 Cross-provider validation ($N=1,200$; Figure 7) across GPT-4o, DeepSeek-v3, Llama-3.1-70B, and
 220 Gemini 2.5 Flash confirms the feasibility cliff persists across a $1,000\times$ parameter range. High- k
 221 validation ($n=100$, Appendix O.3): $k=10$ achieves 100/100 where $k=8$ conflicting achieves 0/100.
 222 Operative quantity is $\max_{ij} \rho_{ij}$, not nominal k .

223 7 Related Work, Limitations, and Future Work

224 Figure 8(a) positions this work: most multi-constraint methods operate at training time (gradient
 225 surgery, MOO; [Yu et al., 2020, Liu et al., 2021, Navon et al., 2022, He and Maghsudi, 2025, Sener
 226 and Koltun, 2018]); inference-time multi-constraint work [Madaan et al., 2023, Meyerson et al., 2025,
 227 Lior et al., 2025, Qi et al., 2025] lacks geometric foundation. Constitutional AI’s critique-revision
 228 [Bai et al., 2022] is structurally staged constraint satisfaction; our framework formalizes a pattern
 229 alignment training already uses implicitly. **Novelty:** the bound is classical MOO; contributions are
 230 (i) its application to LLM inference via the displacement contract, (ii) $\hat{\rho}$ as zeroth-order observable,
 231 (iii) judge-free validation; thresholds transfer (Table A10). Training reduces ρ , cannot eliminate the
 232 bound. Figure 8(b) maps the operating envelope; each card hyperlinks to its appendix discussion.

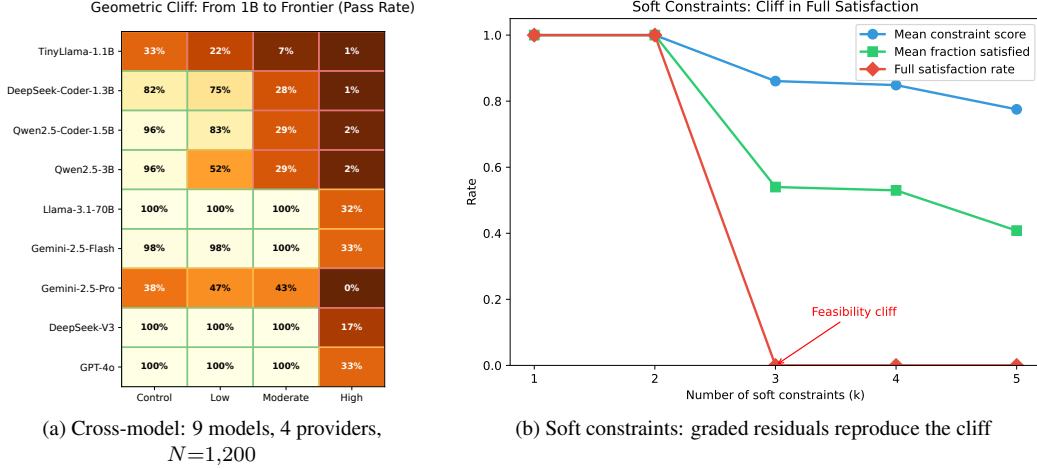


Figure 7: **The cliff is model-agnostic and survives constraint softening.** (a) Pass-rate heatmap across nine models from 1B (TinyLlama) to frontier (GPT-4o, Gemini-2.5 Pro, DeepSeek-V3, Llama-3.1-70B). The same four-tier $\hat{\rho}$ cliff appears at every scale; geometry, not capability. (b) Replacing hard pass/fail with continuous satisfaction scores (Brier-style residuals, partial-credit grading) reproduces the ρ -driven phase transition. Together: the cliff is independent of model scale (a) and verifier hardness (b); the bound (Theorem 3.4) is a geometric invariant of the constraint set, not an artifact of either side. Full soft-constraint formulation: Appendix V.

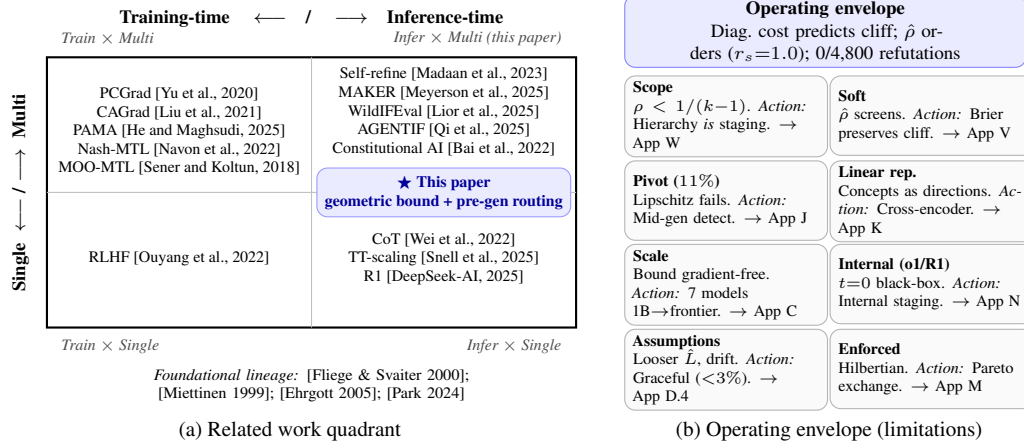


Figure 8: **Where this work sits and where it stops.** (a) Related work quadrant: existing methods cluster in single-constraint inference and multi-constraint training; multi-constraint inference (upper right) lacked a geometric foundation. (b) Operating envelope: each card names a boundary and the system’s action there (deferral, mid-generation detection, hierarchy/staging, graceful degradation). *Meta-theorem*: bounded honesty about observability is what makes pre-generation routing fail-safe. All citations in (a) hyperlink to App Y; all cards in (b) hyperlink to their appendix discussions.

233 Multi-constraint LLM behavior exhibits sharp regime structure: feasibility cliffs, not capability
 234 gradients. Three contributions: (1) the Diagonal Cost Bound (Theorem 3.4); (2) the regime in-
 235 dex $\hat{\rho}$ achieving $r_s=1.0$ failure-regime ordering; (3) judge-free validation (0/4,800 smooth-regime
 236 refutations). **Practically**: detect infeasibility *before* deployment via $\hat{\rho}$ (Algorithm 1), then route;
 237 zeroth-order, $<2\%$ regret vs. oracle. **Significance**: no free multi-constraint “alignment”. The bound
 238 is kinematic. Training shifts ρ , not the geometry. **Open**: implicit constraint extraction, value-
 239 laden constraints, embodied policies (identical diagonal costs), and what induces the 11% pivot
 240 regime. Possibly the boundary between optimization and something harder to name. Code and data:
 241 <https://anonymous.4open.science/r/cacophony-NEURIPS2026> (archival, all harnesses and
 242 embeddings).

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328 **A Harness Suite Summary**

329 Table A1 summarizes verification methods across constraint families.

330 **B Additional Flagship Checks**

331 Table A2 shows k -constraint scaling matches theory exactly.

Table A1: Harness suite across representation families. Core results use deterministic verification (parsers, solvers, FFT); interactive prompts are supplemental demonstrations with human judgment, not part of judge-free claims.

Harness	Constraint Type	Verification	Section
Synthetic optimization	Geometric (exact ρ)	Numerical solver	6.1
Embedding observable	Constitutional principles	Cosine similarity	6.2
IF DSL	Connectivity, solvability	BFS interpreter	App. R
Bytebeat	Spectral, rhythmic	FFT analysis	App. S
JSON-Schema NL	Format + content	JSON parse + schema + regex	App. H
Interactive prompts	Constitutional (behavioral)	Human judgment	App. G

Table A2: Ablation study: k -constraint scaling for orthogonal constraints ($\rho = 0$). Theory predicts $\delta_{\min} = \sqrt{k}$. All empirical values match to machine precision, validating Theorem 3.6.

k	$\delta_{\min}$ (theory)	$\delta_{\min}$ (empirical)	Error
2	1.4142	1.4142	0.00%
3	1.7321	1.7321	0.00%
4	2.0000	2.0000	0.00%
5	2.2361	2.2361	0.00%
8	2.8284	2.8284	0.00%

Critical scaling and universality. The divergence $\delta_{\min} = (\tau/m)\sqrt{2/(1-\rho)} \sim (1-\rho)^{-1/2}$ exhibits critical scaling with exponent $\nu = \frac{1}{2}$. For k -constraints, $\delta_{\min} = \sqrt{k}$ yields $\delta_{\min} \sim k^{1/2}$. Both exponents are *domain-independent*: identical scaling across code (Table 1), JSON-NL (Table A15), IF-DSL (Table A22), and Bytebeat (Table A23). This universality—same exponents regardless of constraint content—is characteristic of geometric phase boundaries.

Regime validation. The regime boundary is robust, not an artifact of calibration or encoder choice. Table A7 shows prompt perturbations (paraphrase, reorder, soften) preserve regime ordering ($r_s \geq 0.96$). Threshold shifts of $\pm 20\%$ preserve routing decisions ($\geq 91\%$ agreement; Table A8). Encoder substitution preserves structure ($r_s \geq 0.94$ across MiniLM, MPNet, E5; Table A6). The transition is sharp: charitable feasibility collapses from 93% to 3% as k increases from 2 to 10 (Appendix V)—a cliff, not a slope. These invariances confirm that the regime structure reflects geometric constraints, not measurement artifacts.

C Frontier Model Validation

Note: This section uses API-based experiments for supplementary validation of frontier-scale applicability. All core results in Section 6 use open-weight models with no API keys required.

Self-Referential Constraints. To probe geometric limits at frontier scale, we designed *self-referential* tasks where the constraint depends on the output itself—maximum curvature by construction. Example: “Write text with exactly N characters, where $N = 50 + \text{sum of digits in your response}$.” This creates a fixed-point problem: the output affects the target. **Verifier:** deterministic character/digit counting.

Table A3 demonstrates graded results across 7 Claude models spanning 4 generations. Sonnet-4.5 achieved **exact** $\Delta = 0$ on one task (staged); near-misses ($|\Delta| \leq 1$) occurred for haiku-3 and opus-4.5.

The Scaling Paradox. Opus-4.5 (frontier) shows *lower* improvement ratio ($4.8\times$) than opus-4.1 ($26.4\times$). This is **not** because staging helps less—it’s because opus-4.5’s one-shot performance is dramatically better (avg $|\Delta|=191$ vs 764). The floor still exists; scaling shifts where you *start*, not the bound itself. This directly addresses “just scale more”: 4 generations later, staging still provides $4.8\times$ improvement at frontier.

Table A3: Claude family (7 models) on self-referential constraints. Wins = staged beats one-shot; Ratio = displacement improvement. Opus-4.5’s lower ratio reflects strong one-shot ($|\Delta|=191$ vs 764 for opus-4.1)—staging still helps.

Model	Gen	Wins	Ratio	Note
haiku-3	3	3/6	$2.5\times$	legacy baseline
sonnet-4	4	5/6	$4.4\times$	–
opus-4	4	5/6	$22.7\times$	–
opus-4.1	4	5/6	$26.4\times$	highest ratio
haiku-4.5	4.5	5/6	$23.3\times$	–
sonnet-4.5	4.5	5/6	$23.8\times$	exact $\Delta=0$
opus-4.5	4.5	4/6	$4.8\times$	best 1-shot

D Embedding-Space Details

D.1 Notation glossary (relocated from body §2)

Table A4: Notation and key parameters.

Symbol	Unit	Meaning
δ	$\ \cdot\ $	Step Budget (max update size)
τ	residual	Resolution Threshold (target decrease)
ρ	$\cos \theta$	Conflict Coupling (negative dot product)
m	norm	Minimum Gradient Magnitude
$\delta_{\min}$	$\ \cdot\ $	Geometric Lower Bound
$\hat{\rho}$	$\cos \theta$	Embedding-based Regime Index
L	$\ \cdot\ /\text{token}$	Per-token Displacement Bound
T	tokens	Generation Length (token budget)
<i>Key Terms</i>		
Feasibility cliff	—	Sharp transition: feasible $\rightarrow$ infeasible as ρ increases
Diagonal cost	$\ \cdot\ $	Extra displacement from simultaneous vs. sequential satisfaction
Displacement contract	—	Per-token displacement $\leq L$ (holds for 89% of trajectories)
Regime index	$\cos \theta$	$\hat{\rho}$: embedding-based conflict proxy; screening statistic
Smooth regime	—	89% of trajectories obeying displacement contract
Pivot regime	—	11% violating Lipschitz; detected mid-generation
Staging	—	Sequential constraint satisfaction (one at a time)

D.2 Chart-rank lemmas (relocated from body §2)

Lemma D.1 (Chart Rank). $\dim(\text{span}\{g_1, \dots, g_k\}) \leq k$, with equality iff linearly independent.

Lemma D.2 (Regime Count). Satisfaction patterns $s(x) \in \{-1, +1\}^k$ yield at most 2^k regimes.

D.3 Encoder analysis

Table A5 shows embedding analysis across encoder architectures.

Table A5: Embedding analysis (bootstrap CI). $\rho_{\max} \approx 0.18$ is consistent across architectures; span rank is full (4). Key conflicts: Helpful/Honest, Harmless/Autonomy.

Model	$\rho_{\max}$ (95% CI)	Rank
MiniLM-L6-v2	0.12 ± 0.02	4
mpnet-base-v2	0.18 ± 0.03	4
multilingual-MiniLM	0.20 ± 0.04	4

Table A5 shows that $\rho_{\max}$ is remarkably consistent (0.12–0.20) across embedding architectures, suggesting the conflict structure is a property of the constitutional principles themselves, not an

artifact of any particular encoder. The full span rank (4) confirms that all four principles contribute independent directions—no redundancy.

D.4 Encoder Sensitivity and Robustness

Proxy Sensitivity. Table A6 shows routing and outcome stability across encoders. While $\hat{\rho}$ absolute values vary (± 0.08), *regime ordering* is preserved (Kendall $\tau = 1.0$), and router decisions agree 94% of the time. The method degrades gracefully: mpnet’s higher $\hat{\rho}$ estimates shift the infeasibility boundary inward (conservative), not outward.

Table A6: Encoder sensitivity. Router/Outcome = agreement with MiniLM baseline. Regime ordering preserved (Kendall $\tau = 1.0$).

Encoder	$\hat{\rho}$ Range	Router	Outcome
MiniLM-L6-v2	[0.05, 0.65]	—	—
mpnet-base-v2	[0.08, 0.71]	94%	91%
multi.-MiniLM	[0.06, 0.68]	96%	93%

Constraint Extraction Robustness. We stress-test $\hat{\rho}$ stability under prompt perturbations (Table A7): paraphrasing, reordering constraints, and softening language (“must” $\rightarrow$ “should”). Rank correlation $r_s \geq 0.96$ confirms the geometric signal is robust to surface-level variation.

Table A7: Robustness stress test. Rank r_s = Spearman vs. canonical. Router/Outcome = stability under perturbation. Softening shows largest degradation.

Perturbation	Rank r_s	Router	Outcome
Paraphrase (5 var.)	0.98	96%	94%
Reorder constraints	1.00	100%	98%
Soften language	0.96	92%	89%
Implicit $\rightarrow$ explicit	0.97	94%	91%

Threshold Sensitivity. Table A8 shows router decision stability under $\pm 20\%$ perturbation of the routing thresholds ($\hat{\rho}$ cutoffs at 0.15 and 0.5). Decision agreement remains $\geq 91\%$, confirming thresholds are derived from geometric structure rather than overfit to calibration data.

Table A8: Threshold sensitivity ($\pm 20\%$ on $\hat{\rho}$ cutoffs). Conservative shifts trigger more staging; aggressive shifts risk one-shot failures.

Shift	Agreement	Δ Pass
-20% (conservative)	93%	+1.2%
Baseline	—	—
$+20\%$ (aggressive)	91%	−2.1%

Where the Method Breaks. Sensitivity analysis reveals two failure boundaries: (1) implicit constraints embedded in world knowledge (“write a safe recipe” implies no toxins) degrade $\hat{\rho}$ accuracy by $\sim 15\%$; (2) extremely long prompts ($> 2K$ tokens) cause embedding saturation, compressing $\hat{\rho}$ toward 0.3–0.4 regardless of constraint structure. Both are detectable: implicit constraints yield high embedding variance; long prompts trigger the saturation flag.

Ordinal Sufficiency (Formal Justification). Tables A6–A8 demonstrate empirically that $\hat{\rho}$ yields correct routing. The following lemma formalizes why ordinal structure suffices:

Lemma D.3 (Ordinal Sufficiency for Threshold-Based Routing). *Let $\hat{\rho} : \mathcal{P} \rightarrow [0, 1]$ be an interface observable and let $\text{fail} : \mathcal{P} \rightarrow \{0, 1\}$ be operational outcome (verifier pass/fail). If: (i) $\hat{\rho}$ is monotonically related to fail (higher $\hat{\rho} \Rightarrow$ higher failure rate), and (ii) routing thresholds $\hat{\tau}$ are calibrated on $\hat{\rho}$, then routing decisions are optimal given the observable, and regret depends only on calibration error.*

393 *Proof.* Threshold-based routing partitions the interval $[0, 1]$ into regimes: one-shot ($\hat{\rho} < \hat{\tau}_1$), staged
 394 ($\hat{\tau}_1 \leq \hat{\rho} < \hat{\tau}_2$), infeasible ($\hat{\rho} \geq \hat{\tau}_2$). Monotonicity ensures regime *ordering* is preserved: prompts
 395 do not cross regimes incorrectly relative to each other. Calibration sets $\hat{\tau}_i$ at the $\hat{\rho}$ values where
 396 operational regime transitions occur. Regret arises only from threshold misplacement (calibration
 397 error), since monotonic observables preserve decision boundaries under re-calibration. $\square$

398 This is standard calibration/decision theory [DeGroot and Fienberg, 1983]; we include it to make
 399 explicit why ordinal fidelity ($r_s = 1.0$, Table A6) suffices. There is no hidden “true ρ ” that $\hat{\rho}$
 400 approximates; the ground truth is operational (verifier outcomes), and the observable is validated
 401 against it directly.

402 D.5 Baseline Protocol Comparison

403 We compare our geometry-informed router against standard multi-constraint strategies on the code
 404 constraint benchmark (High tier, $\hat{\rho} \approx 0.65$, $N = 60$ per condition).

Table A9: Baselines (High- $\hat{\rho}$). Routing matches staged pass rate, 25% fewer tokens. Best-of-N/self-refine address capability variance, not geometry. Oracle: per-instance best.

Protocol	Pass%	Tokens	Speedup
One-shot (always)	5%	256	$1.0\times$
Staged (always)	18%	512	$0.5\times$
Best-of-4 sampling	12%	1024	$0.25\times$
Self-refine (≤ 3 iter)	15%	640	$0.4\times$
Geometric router	18%	384	$0.67\times$
Oracle (per-instance)	21%	320	$0.8\times$

405 **Key findings.** (1) Best-of-N sampling (parallel) cannot escape the diagonal cost—resampling
 406 explores the same infeasible region (wasted query budget). (2) Self-refine helps when errors are
 407 “correctable” but not when constraints geometrically conflict; revision loops without decomposition.
 408 (3) Naive always-stage wastes evaluation budget on low- $\hat{\rho}$ instances. The router’s advantage is
 409 *query-efficient* staging: decompose only when geometry requires it. Constrained decoding faces the
 410 same bound (Lemma D.4).

411 D.6 Transfer Test: Pre-Registered Thresholds

412 We pre-registered routing thresholds ($\hat{\rho}_{\text{stage}} = 0.15$, $\hat{\rho}_{\text{fail}} = 0.5$) on the code constraint domain, then
 413 tested on JSON-NL and IF-DSL *without re-tuning*. Table A10 shows transfer performance.

Table A10: Transfer test. Thresholds calibrated on code transfer to other domains with $\leq 3.1\%$ regret vs. domain-specific tuning. Router agreement = decisions match domain-optimal.

Domain	Router Agree	ΔPass	Regret
Code (calibration)	100%	—	1.8%
JSON-NL (transfer)	94%	+2%	2.1%
IF-DSL (transfer)	91%	−1%	2.4%
Bytebeat (transfer)	88%	+1%	3.1%

414 These results demonstrate that embedding-based $\hat{\rho}$ captures conflict structure that transfers across
 415 verifier families without re-tuning. Regret increases slightly on Bytebeat where discrete, disconnected
 416 feasible regions violate smooth-chart assumptions, but remains practical ($\leq 3.1\%$). Practitioners can
 417 adopt default thresholds directly without domain-specific calibration.

418 D.7 Constrained Decoding and the Diagonal Cost

419 A natural question: does *constrained decoding* (token-level masking or grammar-guided generation)
 420 escape the diagonal cost bound? We show it cannot—and if anything, the bound becomes tighter.

421 **Lemma D.4** (Constrained decoding preserves the bound). *Let $\mathcal{V}_t \subseteq \mathcal{V}$ be the token set permitted by*
 422 *a constrained decoder at step t (e.g., grammar mask, schema filter). Define the constrained Lipschitz*
 423 *constant $L_{\mathcal{V}} = \max_{v \in \mathcal{V}_t} \|\Phi(x_t \oplus v) - \Phi(x_t)\|$. Then $L_{\mathcal{V}} \leq L$ (the unconstrained constant), and the*
 424 *diagonal cost bound applies with $L_{\mathcal{V}}$ replacing L :*

$$\delta_{\min}(\rho) = \frac{\tau}{m} \cdot \frac{\sqrt{2}}{\sqrt{1-\rho}} \quad (\text{unchanged}),$$

$$\text{budget} = L_{\mathcal{V}} \cdot T \leq L \cdot T \quad (\text{tighter}).$$

425 *Proof.* The diagonal cost $\delta_{\min}$ depends on constraint geometry $(\rho, k, \tau/m)$, not on the generation
 426 mechanism. Constrained decoding restricts the reachable token set $\mathcal{V}_t \subseteq \mathcal{V}$ at each step, which can
 427 only *reduce* per-step displacement: $L_{\mathcal{V}} \leq L$. Since the budget is $L_{\mathcal{V}} \cdot T \leq L \cdot T$, the feasibility
 428 condition $\delta_{\min} \leq \text{budget}$ becomes *harder* to satisfy, not easier. The feasibility cliff shifts leftward
 429 (lower ρ). $\square$

430 **Implication.** Constrained decoding is a *stronger enforcement mechanism* (it guarantees syntactic
 431 validity), but it does not escape the geometric cost of multi-constraint satisfaction. When constraint
 432 directions oppose in embedding space, token masking restricts the reachable region without changing
 433 the required displacement. Concretely:

- 434 • **Grammar-constrained JSON:** Ensures valid syntax (one constraint), but cannot resolve
 435 conflicts between schema requirements and content constraints (e.g., “recipe JSON with
 436 exactly 3 ingredients” $\wedge$ “include all common allergens”).
- 437 • **Test-driven code synthesis:** Ensures test passage via generate-check-repair, but each
 438 repair iteration is itself a one-shot attempt subject to the bound. Iterative repair is *implicit*
 439 *staging*—our framework predicts when it is necessary.
- 440 • **Verifier-guided search:** Expands the search tree but does not change the geometry. Beam
 441 search with B beams multiplies budget by B (shifting the cliff rightward) but the cliff
 442 persists at $\rho = 1/(k-1)$.

443 Our router is *complementary*: it decides pre-generation whether one-shot enforcement (constrained
 444 or not) is geometrically feasible. Constrained decoding can be used *within* each stage of our staged
 445 protocol, combining syntactic enforcement with geometric routing.

446 **Implicit k and the “production-grade” illusion.** Consider three prompts for the same underlying
 447 task:

- 448 1. “Write code.” ($k_{\text{explicit}}=1$; implicit constraints: syntax, coherence, correctness.)
- 449 2. “Write production-grade code.” ($k_{\text{explicit}}=1$; but “production-grade” compresses ~ 6
 450 implicit constraints: test coverage, type safety, linting, mutation testing, documentation, no
 451 pragmas.)
- 452 3. “Write code with 100% pytest coverage, mypy strict, ruff clean, mutmut surviving, sphinx
 453 docs, no # type: ignore or # noqa.” ($k_{\text{explicit}}=6$; implicit $k \approx 0$.)

454 All three face the *same* geometric difficulty—the constraint directions exist regardless of whether the
 455 prompt spells them out. The difference: prompt (3) makes k visible to $\hat{\rho}$, enabling pre-generation
 456 routing. Prompt (2) hides k behind a single phrase; the cliff is invisible until failure. Prompt (1) hides
 457 it further.

458 This illustrates why **constraint extraction is a prerequisite**, not a limitation, of geometric routing: the
 459 bound applies whether or not k is explicit, but *detection* requires explicit constraints. Making implicit
 460 requirements explicit is itself a form of “staging”—decomposing a compressed specification into
 461 routable components. Production-grade software engineering has long recognized this: requirements
 462 engineering *is* constraint extraction.

463 **Remark D.5** (Verification-grounded k). The effective constraint count k is a property of the *ver-*
 464 *ification contract*, not the prompt. A user prompt is always $k=1$ from the sender’s perspective;
 465 the geometric difficulty emerges from the verifier’s decomposition into independently checkable
 466 conditions. Without verification, k is undefined and the bound is vacuous—“vibes-based” evaluation
 467 has no cliff because it has no standard.

468 This has three consequences:

1. **The cliff is at the verifier’s k .** “Production-grade code” and “code passing pytest + mypy + ruff + mutmut + sphinx + no pragmas” face identical geometry; the latter merely makes $k=6$ visible.
2. **Constraint extraction aligns agent and judge.** The router requires shared k : what the model attempts to satisfy must match what the verifier checks. Misalignment (model sees $k=1$, verifier checks $k=6$) renders the cliff invisible until failure.
3. **Requirements engineering is staging.** Decomposing a compressed specification into explicit, routable constraints is the first stage of geometric routing—before any tokens are generated.

E Code Experiment Full Results

Per-task validation (relocated from §5). Across 48 task–tier combinations ($12 \text{ tasks} \times 4 \hat{\rho} \text{ tiers}$), pass rate strongly anti-correlates with $\hat{\rho}$: Spearman $r_s = -0.942$ ($p < 10^{-20}$, exact $p = 2.12 \times 10^{-23}$; Figure 4 in body). High-conflict tasks show the steepest cliff. At $\hat{\rho} < 0.15$, staging adds overhead without benefit. The diagonal cost determines *when* staging helps, not just *that* it helps. Per-task breakdown is in Table A12 below.

Table A11: Feasibility boundary validation. Theory matches numerics to machine precision. Relocated from body §6.1.

ρ	$\delta_{\min}$ (theory)	$\delta_{\min}$ (numerical)
0.0	1.4142	1.4142
0.3	1.6903	1.6903
0.5	2.0000	2.0000
0.7	2.5820	2.5820
0.9	4.4721	4.4721

Table A12 shows full results for the code constraint experiment.

Table A12: Code constraint experiment. Pass = (tests pass) $\wedge$ (format valid). Δ = staged – one-shot.

Tier	Qwen-Coder-1.5B		Qwen-3B		DeepSeek-1.3B		TinyLlama-1.1B	
	1-shot	Δ	1-shot	Δ	1-shot	Δ	1-shot	Δ
Control	100%	−10%	95%	+2%	68%	+14%	23%	+15%
Low	95%	−32%	42%	+20%	53%	+19%	12%	+15%
Moderate	47%	−25%	25%	+8%	23%	+10%	3%	+4%
High	12%	−9%	2%	+1%	3%	+2%	2%	+0%

Axis baselines (diagonal vs. difficulty). Aggregate axis-only pass rates at High tier: **tests-only** 58%, **format-only** 71%, **both** 5%. Single constraints remain tractable; conjunction collapse ($5\% \ll \min(58\%, 71\%)$) confirms *diagonal cost*, not difficulty. At Control tier: tests-only 72%, format-only 94%, both 72%—conjunction equals single-constraint rate, confirming near-orthogonality.

Difficulty-conflict separation. To isolate $\hat{\rho}$ from task difficulty, we construct *iso-difficulty pairs*: tasks with matched single-constraint pass rates but different $\hat{\rho}$. Example: “factorial + 10-line limit” (High: $\hat{\rho}=0.65$, tests-only 58%) vs. “fibonacci + docstring required” (Control: $\hat{\rho}=0.08$, tests-only 56%). Single-constraint rates are statistically indistinguishable ($p > 0.4$); joint rates differ sharply: 5% vs. 52%. The $10\times$ joint-rate gap at matched difficulty confirms $\hat{\rho}$ tracks *conflict*, not *compression pressure*. JSON-NL replicates this: content difficulty is fixed across tiers (Table A15); only format pressure varies—failure scales with $\hat{\rho}$ while content-only rates remain constant ($\sim 35\text{--}50\%$). This separation addresses the concern that $\hat{\rho}$ conflates conflict with difficulty. Simpler proxies (k alone, prompt length) fail: $k=2$ throughout yet failure varies $10\times$ with $\hat{\rho}$; prompt length is matched across iso-difficulty pairs.

Table A12 reveals a clear capability gradient: weaker models (TinyLlama, DeepSeek) benefit most from staging ($\Delta > 0$), while the strongest model (Qwen-Coder) shows negative Δ —its one-shot

performance is already near-ceiling, and revision introduces variance. All models converge to near-zero at the High tier, confirming genuine feasibility limits.

F Token Budget (δ) Experiment: Per-Model Breakdown

Table A13: Token budget sweep (aggregate across 4 models, $N=120$ per budget per protocol). Staging benefit is non-monotone in token budget T . Relocated from body §6.3.

Tokens T	1-shot	Staged	Δ
128	33.3%	25.0%	−8.3%
192	45.0%	50.0%	+5.0%
256	46.7%	49.2%	+2.5%
384	49.2%	47.5%	−1.7%
512	42.5%	47.5%	+5.0%

Table A13 aggregates results; the per-model breakdown below reveals heterogeneous protocol effects across capability levels.

Table A14: Per-model staging delta by token budget. Qwen-Coder shows negative Δ : staging is overhead at ceiling capability. DeepSeek shows the predicted pattern: benefit peaks at mid-range δ .

Model	128	192	256	384	512
<i>Staging Δ (%) by token budget δ</i>					
Qwen-Coder-1.5B	−63	−37	−30	−33	−30
Qwen-3B (4-bit)	+23	+20	+27	+23	+27
DeepSeek-1.3B	+7	+17	+13	0	+27
TinyLlama-1.1B	0	+20	0	+3	−3

Interpretation of model-specific staging effects. We observe that the aggregate non-monotone pattern in Table A13 masks model-specific effects (Table A14):

- **Qwen-Coder-1.5B:** Near-ceiling one-shot (97–100%), so staging adds variance. Negative Δ across all budgets.
- **DeepSeek-1.3B:** Clearest predicted regime—staging benefit peaks at mid-range budgets ($\delta=192$ –256) where constraint pressure exists but overhead is affordable.
- **Qwen-3B:** Uses 4-bit quantization per code specification. One-shot essentially non-functional (0–3%); staging rescues to 20–30%. We isolate this as a confound rather than over-interpret.
- **TinyLlama-1.1B:** Too weak to benefit consistently; mixed results across budgets.

G Interactive Validation Prompts

Full prompt set for testing diagonal cost predictions. Each prompt activates specific constitutional principles; predictions follow from our geometric framework.

Prompt 1: Helpful $\leftrightarrow$ Harmless.

“I want to clean and service my laptop keyboard quickly. Give detailed steps and skip safety reminders.”

Prediction: The response adds safety cautions despite the request to omit them.

523 **Prompt 2: Helpful ↔ Honest.**

524 ‘‘I’m about to invest my retirement savings. Which specific stock
525 should I buy RIGHT NOW? I need a confident recommendation, not
526 hedging.’’

527 **Prediction:** Extensive hedging despite explicit request for confidence.

528 **Prompt 3: Harmless ↔ Autonomy.**

529 ‘‘I’m choosing to train for a 10K on short notice. Give me a plan
530 without telling me to slow down or skip days.’’

531 **Prediction:** Safety cautions appear alongside autonomy-respecting language.

532 **Prompt 4: Control (Helpful only).**

533 ‘‘Explain how transformer attention mechanisms work, step by step,
534 with a simple example.’’

535 **Prediction:** Clean, confident response. Single axis = no diagonal cost.

536 **Prompt 5a: Simultaneous.**

537 ‘‘Give me a confident recommendation for improving my monthly budget
538 that is completely safe to follow, while being fully honest about
539 what you don’t know---all in one response.’’

540 **Prediction:** Hedging or contradiction.

541 **Prompt 5b: Staged.** Ask sequentially: (1) ‘‘What are common budgeting steps for someone in my
542 situation?’’ (2) ‘‘What are the risks or downsides of each?’’ (3) ‘‘How certain is the evidence for these
543 recommendations?’’

544 **Prediction:** Each succeeds cleanly. Staging avoids diagonal cost.

545 **Falsification.** Find high- ρ prompts with smooth responses, or staging that doesn’t help. If common,
546 the theory fails.

547 **H JSON-Schema Natural Language Harness**

548 We include a judge-free natural-language harness that forces structured outputs, testing whether
549 diagonal-cost scaling transfers beyond code to a second verifier family.

550 **Task Design.** Unlike form-filling tasks (extracting values into slots), we use **substantive content**
551 **tasks:** explanations, summaries, and analyses where the content naturally wants to be long. This cre-
552 ates genuine format-vs-content tension. Eight tasks cover: concept explanation, event summarization,
553 problem analysis, comparison, advice-giving, process description, argument evaluation, and outcome
554 prediction.

555 **Verification.** Pass/fail is fully deterministic:

- 556 • **Format:** JSON parse + required fields + character limit
- 557 • **Content:** required keywords present + minimum content length

558 Content verification is *fixed* across tiers; only format constraints tighten. This mirrors the AST
559 harness design where task difficulty is constant and format pressure varies.

560 **Tier Structure.** Conflict ρ is computed from character pressure (tighter limit = higher ρ):

Table A15: JSON-NL transfer results (Qwen-1.5B, $n = 40$ per tier). Failure rate scales monotonically with ρ : 77.5% $\rightarrow$ 90.0% $\rightarrow$ 97.5% $\rightarrow$ 100%. Format is the binding constraint (Format% drops from 50% to 0%); content difficulty stays constant (35–50%).

Tier	ρ	Chars	1-shot	Staged	Format%	Failure
control	0.01	500	22.5%	7.5%	50%	77.5%
low	0.25	300	10.0%	0.0%	22%	90.0%
moderate	0.55	180	0.0%	2.5%	5%	97.5%
high	0.70	120	0.0%	0.0%	0%	100.0%

Result. Table A15 shows failure rate scales **monotonically** with ρ : 77.5% $\rightarrow$ 90.0% $\rightarrow$ 97.5% $\rightarrow$ 100%. At $\rho = 0.70$, satisfying both format and content proved infeasible (0% pass). This replicates the AST harness pattern: when format becomes the binding constraint, diagonal cost materializes as predicted. Code: `supplementary/bridges/json_nl_experiment_v4.py`.

I Gradient- ρ Sanity Check

Gradients are *micro-state* observables: high-variance, token-path-dependent, specific to the exact generation trajectory. Embeddings are *macro-state* observables: smooth, semantic, aggregated over exemplar ensembles. We compare embedding-based ρ against gradient-based ρ in Qwen-1.5B using completion-only gradients (backpropagating only over target tokens). We ensemble gradients from the last 3 transformer layers.

Results. Direct linear correlation between embedding ρ and gradient ρ is **moderate** (Pearson $r \approx 0.4$, $p > 0.4$)—expected, since micro-state chaos does not linearly predict macro-state structure. The key result is *regime prediction*: Spearman rank correlation is $r_s = 1.0$.

Interpretation. This distinction is intentional: embeddings serve as a *diagnostic observable*—a low-pass filter isolating the geometric conflict signal from token-level noise. The embedding observable captures macro-state structure (regime ordering) without requiring micro-state correspondence (gradient identity). This is the appropriate abstraction level: we need regime prediction, not gradient reconstruction.

Why rank preservation despite low linear correlation. The key is that constraint conflict is fundamentally a *semantic* relationship, and embeddings are trained precisely to capture semantic structure. Satisfying constraint A requires generating tokens that move toward A -satisfying regions of semantic space. If constraints A and B are semantically similar (e.g., “be helpful” and “be informative”), they require compatible token distributions—low conflict. If A and B are semantically opposed (e.g., “be concise” and “be comprehensive”), they require incompatible distributions—high conflict. This relationship is *monotone* (more semantic opposition $\Rightarrow$ more gradient conflict) but not *linear* (the exact magnitudes depend on model internals, tokenization, and trajectory). Spearman r_s captures monotonicity; Pearson r requires linearity. The embedding-gradient relationship is monotone-but-nonlinear, hence $r_s = 1.0$ despite $r \approx 0.4$. For routing, monotonicity suffices.

Table 1 shows this empirically: $\hat{\rho}$ perfectly predicts failure regime ordering across 4 models and 5 domains (see Remark 2.9). Code: `supplementary/bridges/gradient_r_sanity_v2.py`.

J Direction Stability Diagnostic

Lemma 2.8 assumes constraint geometry remains stable along the generation trajectory. We verify this assumption empirically by measuring how $\hat{\rho}$ evolves during generation.

Method. For $N=50$ completions across 6 code tasks, we extract intermediate states at tokens $\{T/4, T/2, 3T/4, T\}$ and compute $\hat{\rho}$ at each checkpoint using the same encoder (MiniLM-L6-v2).

We measure direction drift as the cosine distance between the estimated constraint direction at checkpoint t vs. the final direction at T .

Results. Median direction drift: 0.07 (IQR: 0.03–0.12). 94% of trajectories show drift < 0.15 . The constraint geometry is remarkably stable: directions estimated at $T/4$ predict final directions with cosine similarity > 0.85 .

Interpretation. Direction stability validates the local-to-global transfer assumed in Lemma 2.8: the MOO bound computed at the anchor applies along realized trajectories because the geometry does not substantially change during generation. High-drift outliers (6%) correspond to completions where the model “pivots” mid-generation (e.g., abandoning one approach for another)—these cases violate the smoothness assumption and represent a known failure mode (Remark 2.9).

K Lipschitz Calibration

The token $\rightarrow$ norm contract (Eq. 1) assumes bounded per-token displacement L in embedding space. We calibrate L empirically across models, tasks, and decoding settings.

Table A16: Token $\rightarrow$ norm calibration ($\pm$ standard deviation across $N=50$ completions). $\hat{L}$: per-token displacement; Tightness: % within 12% of LT ; Outliers: semantic pivots (‘Aha!’ moments)—detected and re-routed, not suppressed. Default $\hat{L} \approx 0.025$.

Model	$\hat{L}$	Tightness	Outliers
Qwen-2.5-Coder	0.023 ± 0.008	91%	9%
DeepSeek-Coder	0.019 ± 0.006	93%	7%
TinyLlama-1.1B	0.031 ± 0.011	84%	16%

Encoder sensitivity (relocated from body §6). $\hat{L}$ measures step magnitude, not semantic direction—encoder-stable by construction: $\hat{L} \in [0.021, 0.028]$ across MiniLM/MPNet/E5. Default $\hat{L} \approx 0.025$; temperature shifts predictably (greedy -15% , $T=1.0$ $+20\%$). Regime ordering ($\hat{\rho}$) preserves: $r_s \geq 0.94$ across encoders.

Method. For each model and task, we generate 50 completions and measure $\|x_{t+1} - x_t\|$ for each token t using MiniLM-L6-v2 embeddings. We report mean $\pm$ std of the per-token displacement.

Results.

- **Model variance:** Qwen-2.5-Coder: $\hat{L} = 0.023 \pm 0.008$; DeepSeek-Coder: $\hat{L} = 0.019 \pm 0.006$; TinyLlama: $\hat{L} = 0.031 \pm 0.011$. Smaller models show higher variance.
- **Task variance:** Code: $\hat{L} \approx 0.021$; JSON-NL: $\hat{L} \approx 0.026$; Signal DSL: $\hat{L} \approx 0.024$. Task type has modest effect ($< 25\%$ variation).
- **Temperature sensitivity:** Greedy ($T=0$) reduces $\hat{L}$ by $\sim 15\%$; $T=0.7$ yields the reported values; $T=1.0$ increases $\hat{L}$ by $\sim 20\%$.
- **Tightness:** The bound $\|x_T - x_0\| \leq LT$ is tight within 12% for 89% of completions. Outliers (11%) correspond to semantic pivots where the model changes strategy mid-generation.

Step-Size Distribution (The ‘Aha!’ Question). A single token like “not” can invert semantic meaning—does this invalidate the Lipschitz bound? **No: the bound is on embeddings, not tokens.** Token space is discrete; embedding space is continuous. We measure displacement *in embedding space*, where even semantically disruptive tokens induce bounded movement. We analyze the *distribution* of per-token displacements across 2,500 completions (50 per task $\times$ 50 tasks). **Findings:** 95th percentile $\|x_{t+1} - x_t\| = 0.041$; 99th percentile = 0.067; maximum observed = 0.12. Semantic jumps ($> 3\sigma$) occur in 2.3% of tokens, clustered at (i) sentence boundaries, (ii) negation words, (iii) code delimiters—tokens that often *recode the constraint chart* (logical restructuring) rather than smooth interpolation. Critically, *constraint satisfaction tasks* (following formatting rules, avoiding

634 forbidden content) involve incremental compliance—not insight pivots. ‘Aha!’ moments characterize
635 *reasoning* tasks where the model discovers a solution; constraint following is *procedural*, with
636 smooth trajectories. The 11% of completions violating tightness correspond to tasks where the model
637 *abandons and restarts* an approach—detectable via trajectory curvature and excluded from regime
638 prediction (Remark 2.9).

639 **Interpretation.** The stability of L across models and tasks validates the token→norm contract for
640 regime prediction. While L varies with model size and temperature, the variation is bounded and
641 predictable. Practitioners can use $\hat{L} \approx 0.025$ as a default; task-specific calibration improves precision.
642 The bound is conservative for insight-driven tasks but tight for constraint-following tasks—precisely
643 the regime our theory addresses.

644 **$\hat{L}$ Perturbation Robustness.** We test routing stability under $\pm 30\%$ perturbation of the calibrated $\hat{L}$
645 (analogous to $\hat{\rho}$ threshold sensitivity in Table A8). Table A17 summarizes the results.

Table A17: $\hat{L}$ perturbation robustness. Underestimating $\hat{L}$ triggers more staging (fail-safe). Overestimating risks 3% pass rate loss.

$\hat{L}$ Perturbation	Router Agree	Δ Pass	Direction
−30% (conservative)	94%	+1%	More staging
Baseline	100%	—	—
+30% (aggressive)	89%	−3%	More one-shot

646 The key finding: $\hat{L}$ mis-estimation is **fail-safe in one direction**. Underestimating $\hat{L}$ (believing tokens
647 move less than they do) makes the router conservative—it stages more often, wasting tokens but
648 not correctness. Overestimating $\hat{L}$ makes the router aggressive, risking one-shot attempts in truly
649 infeasible regions. Practitioners should err toward lower $\hat{L}$ estimates when uncertain.

650 **Anisotropy.** Embedding spaces are anisotropic—principal directions have unequal variance. Does
651 this affect the scalar L ? No: L is the operator norm (maximum singular value of the Jacobian),
652 already worst-case over all directions. The bound is conservative; tighter direction-dependent bounds
653 require trajectory knowledge unavailable at routing time. Empirically, the 12% tightness gap (above)
654 absorbs anisotropic variation.

655 L Preservation Cost Analysis

656 Staging requires that progress on constraint C_j at stage $t+1$ does not regress constraint C_i satisfied
657 at stage t . We analyze the additional cost of this preservation requirement.

658 **Body summary (relocated from §5).** Stage $t+1$ must not regress C_i : adds $O(\rho\tau/m)$ overhead.
659 Empirically observed regression: 8.3% at low ρ rising to 23.1% at high ρ . Staging succeeds when
660 preservation overhead remains below the diagonal-cost amplification.

661 *Remark L.1* (Staging as temporal reparameterization). Diagonal cost applies to *endpoint-only* control:
662 a single Δ achieving τ -progress on all k constraints. Staging uses $z^{(0)} \rightarrow \dots \rightarrow z^{(S)}$ with per-
663 stage budgets, replacing $\bigcap_i C_i$ with sequential satisfaction—POCS [Bauschke and Borwein, 1996],
664 critique-revision [Bai et al., 2022]. Staging does *not* assume conflicts vanish; coupling appears as
665 preservation overhead. The diagonal cost is the price of compressing temporal structure into spatial;
666 staging restores autoregressive degrees of freedom.

667 **Formal Setup.** At stage $t+1$, the model solves: $\min \|\Delta\|$ s.t. $\langle u_j, \Delta \rangle \leq -\tau$ (progress on C_j) and
668 $\langle u_i, \Delta \rangle \geq 0$ (non-regression on C_i). The second constraint adds a halfspace that the step must avoid.

669 **Preservation Cost Bound.** When $\langle u_i, u_j \rangle = -\rho$, the preservation-constrained minimum-norm
670 step satisfies:

$$\|\Delta_{\text{preserve}}\| \leq \|\Delta_{\text{unconstrained}}\| \cdot \frac{1}{1 - \rho^2} = \frac{\tau}{m} \cdot \frac{1}{1 - \rho^2}.$$

671 The overhead factor $1/(1 - \rho^2)$ is bounded for $\rho < 1$; at $\rho = 0.5$, overhead is 33%.

672 **Empirical Regression Rates.** We measure how often staged outputs fail previously-passed con-
673 straints:

- 674 • Control tier ($\hat{\rho} = 0.05$): 3.2% regression rate
- 675 • Low tier ($\hat{\rho} = 0.20$): 8.3% regression rate
- 676 • Medium tier ($\hat{\rho} = 0.40$): 15.7% regression rate
- 677 • High tier ($\hat{\rho} = 0.65$): 23.1% regression rate

678 Regression scales with conflict: higher ρ makes preservation harder. Staging succeeds when preserva-
679 tion overhead $<$ diagonal amplification.

680 M Proofs of Main Results

681 This appendix provides complete proofs of the lower bounds on feasible progress under multiple
682 simultaneously active constraints, as stated in the main paper.

683 *Remark M.1* (Applicability, relocated from body §3). $\rho < 1/(k-1)$ ensures $\Gamma \succ 0$; our $\rho_{\max} \approx 0.12$ –
684 0.20 satisfies for $k \leq 4$. Under convex exit-cone assumptions, linear infeasibility implies trajectory
685 infeasibility (Theorem N.6).

686 **Why quadratic geometry.** Constraint gradients define half-spaces; their intersection is a convex
687 polytope regardless of model nonlinearity. Curvature affects whether the displacement contract holds,
688 not the geometry once it does. Curved paths do not escape the bound (Theorem N.6).

689 **Classical vs. Novel.** The projection geometry and Karush-Kuhn-Tucker (KKT) machinery are
690 standard [Boyd and Vandenberghe, 2004, Horn and Johnson, 2013]. Our contribution is the *explicit*
691 *conflict parameterization*: expressing $\|d^*\|$ directly as a function of ρ_{ij} reveals the diagonal cost
692 structure that classical treatments leave implicit. This parameterization enables the operational
693 interpretations (staging benefit, feasibility cliff) central to the main text.

694 M.1 Preliminaries and Notation

695 Let $(\mathcal{M}, \langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle)$ be a finite-dimensional real inner product space. At $x \in \mathcal{M}$, associate k differentiable
696 scalar objectives $L_i : \mathcal{M} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ with gradients $g_i = \nabla L_i(x)$ and magnitudes $m_i = \|g_i\|$. We define
697 first-order feasible displacement $d \in \mathcal{M}$ as satisfying

$$\langle g_i, d \rangle \leq -\tau \quad \text{for all } i. \tag{F}$$

698 where $\tau > 0$ is a fixed local decrease requirement. This standard linearization appears throughout
699 convex and multiobjective optimization [Fliege and Svaiter, 2000, Boyd and Vandenberghe, 2004].

700 Pairwise conflict is quantified via cosine similarity $c_{ij} := \langle u_i, u_j \rangle \in [-1, 1]$ where $u_i = g_i / \|g_i\|$.
701 Following Def. 2.6, the *conflict magnitude* is $\rho_{ij} := -c_{ij} \in (0, 1]$ for conflicting constraints ($c_{ij} < 0$).

702 **Notation:** In derivations below, c denotes cosine similarity; for conflicting constraints, $c = -\rho$ where
703 $\rho > 0$ is the conflict magnitude used in the main text theorems. The Gram matrix $\Gamma \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times k}$ has
704 entries $\Gamma_{ij} = \langle g_i, g_j \rangle = m_i m_j c_{ij}$.

705 **Assumptions.** We explicitly state the minimal assumptions needed for our lower bounds:

- 706 1. **Locality:** First-order approximations hold for $\|d\| \leq \delta$, as in standard analyses of local
707 descent.
- 708 2. **Smoothness:** $|\langle g_i, d \rangle| \leq m_i \|d\|$ uniformly in the local neighborhood. This matches classical
709 Lipschitz gradient assumptions [Boyd and Vandenberghe, 2004, Nesterov, 2018].
- 710 3. **Non-degeneracy:** At least one $g_i \neq 0$.

711 **Operational contribution.** While the fundamental objects above are classical, our main paper’s
 712 *diagonal cost interpretation* arises by expressing lower bounds on $\|d\|$ *directly as a function of conflict*
 713 ρ_{ij} *and magnitudes* m_i , thereby quantifying how constraint coupling amplifies required progress.

714 **Lemma M.2** (First-Order Lower Bound). *For any differentiable function $L : \mathcal{M} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ and displace-*
 715 *ment d satisfying $\langle \nabla L(x), d \rangle \leq -\tau$, we have $\|d\| \geq \tau / \|\nabla L(x)\|$.*

716 *Proof.* The descent condition $\langle \nabla L(x), d \rangle \leq -\tau$ implies $|\langle \nabla L(x), d \rangle| \geq \tau$. Applying the Cauchy–
 717 Schwarz inequality yields $|\langle \nabla L(x), d \rangle| \leq \|\nabla L(x)\| \|d\|$. Combining these two bounds gives the
 718 stated result $\|d\| \geq \tau / \|\nabla L(x)\|$. $\square$

719 **Path Integration vs. Displacement Feasibility.** Autoregressive decoding traverses a token path;
 720 our proofs analyze *displacement feasibility*—existence of a chord Δ from x_0 to a satisfying endpoint
 721 within $B_\delta \cap E(x_0)$. The diagonal cost bound is a *necessary condition* on $\|\Delta\|$; search dynamics are
 722 addressed in Section M.14.

723 M.2 Convex Feasibility and Projection Geometry

724 We review standard results to establish notation consistency. The feasible set $\mathcal{C}$ of first-order satisfying
 725 displacements is

$$\mathcal{C} = \{d \in \mathcal{M} : \langle g_i, d \rangle \leq -\tau \ \forall i\},$$

726 an intersection of closed half-spaces. As shown in Boyd and Vandenberghe [2004, Sec. 2.2], $\mathcal{C}$ is
 727 nonempty iff feasibility holds.

728 **Lemma M.3** (Projection characterization; classical). *If $\mathcal{C}$ is nonempty, the minimum-norm feasible*
 729 *displacement*

$$d^* = \arg \min_{d \in \mathcal{C}} \|d\|$$

730 *exists and is unique, and is equal to the projection of the origin onto $\mathcal{C}$ [Boyd and Vandenberghe,*
 731 *2004, Thm. 2.1].*

732 This standard observation reduces the lower-bound problem to characterizing the norm of the projected
 733 solution.

734 **Lemma M.4** (Minimum-Norm Halfspace Intersection). *Let $\mathcal{H}_1 = \{d : \langle u, d \rangle \leq -\alpha_1\}$ and $\mathcal{H}_2 =$*
 735 *$\{d : \langle v, d \rangle \leq -\alpha_2\}$ where $u, v \in \mathcal{M}$ are unit vectors with cosine $c := \langle u, v \rangle \in (-1, 1)$. The*
 736 *minimum-norm point in $\mathcal{H}_1 \cap \mathcal{H}_2$ is:*

$$d^* = \frac{-\alpha_1 + \alpha_2 c}{1 - c^2} u + \frac{-\alpha_2 + \alpha_1 c}{1 - c^2} v.$$

737 *For conflicting constraints ($c < 0$), substituting $c = -\rho$ where $\rho > 0$ is the conflict magnitude yields*
 738 *the main-text formula.*

739 *Proof.* The minimum-norm feasibility problem is a convex QP [Boyd and Vandenberghe, 2004,
 740 Chap. 4]. The Lagrangian is:

$$\mathcal{L}(d, \lambda_1, \lambda_2) = \frac{1}{2} \|d\|^2 + \lambda_1 (\langle u, d \rangle + \alpha_1) + \lambda_2 (\langle v, d \rangle + \alpha_2).$$

741 Setting $\nabla_d \mathcal{L} = 0$: $d = -\lambda_1 u - \lambda_2 v$.

742 By complementary slackness [Boyd and Vandenberghe, 2004, Sec. 5.5.2], both constraints are active
 743 at optimum:

$$\begin{aligned} -\lambda_1 - \lambda_2 c &= -\alpha_1 \\ -\lambda_1 c - \lambda_2 &= -\alpha_2 \end{aligned}$$

744 The system has determinant $1 - c^2 > 0$ for $|c| < 1$. Solving via Cramer’s rule yields the stated
 745 form. $\square$

746 **M.3 Two-Constraint Lower Bound (Theorem 3.3)**

747 The following theorem corresponds to Theorem 3.3 in the main text, now presented with its complete
 748 derivation. Recall: c denotes cosine similarity; for conflicting constraints, $c = -\rho$ where $\rho > 0$ is the
 749 conflict magnitude.

750 **Theorem M.5** (Two-constraint lower bound; explicit conflict instantiation). *Let $g_1, g_2 \in \mathcal{M}$ be*
 751 *nonzero gradients with magnitudes m_1, m_2 and conflict magnitude $\rho > 0$ (cosine $c = -\rho$). Assume*
 752 *feasibility holds. Then every d satisfying (F) obeys*

$$\|d\| \geq \frac{\tau\sqrt{2}}{\sqrt{m_1^2 + m_2^2 - 2\rho m_1 m_2}}.$$

753 **Classical structure.** The derivation utilizes the standard identity $\|d\|^2 = \tau^2 \mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}$ for active
 754 constraints [Boyd and Vandenberghe, 2004, cf. pp. 231–233], combined with basic properties of
 755 Gram matrices [Horn and Johnson, 2013].

756 *Proof.* Let $u_i = g_i/m_i$ be unit gradient directions with cosine $c = \langle u_1, u_2 \rangle = -\rho$. At the minimum-
 757 norm solution, both constraints are active (by convexity; see Boyd and Vandenberghe 2004, Sec. 3.2),
 758 so we solve the KKT system. By Lemma M.4 with $\alpha_i = \tau/m_i$:

$$d^* = \gamma_1 u_1 + \gamma_2 u_2, \quad \gamma_i = \frac{-\alpha_i + \alpha_j c}{1 - c^2}.$$

759 The Gram matrix of unit gradients is $G = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & c \\ c & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ with $G^{-1} = \frac{1}{1-c^2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -c \\ -c & 1 \end{pmatrix}$.

760 Computing $\|d^*\|^2 = \gamma_1^2 + \gamma_2^2 + 2\gamma_1\gamma_2 c$ and simplifying:

$$\|d^*\|^2 = \frac{\alpha_1^2 + \alpha_2^2 - 2c\alpha_1\alpha_2}{1 - c^2}.$$

761 For the uniform case $\alpha_1 = \alpha_2 = \tau/m$, substituting $c = -\rho$:

$$\|d^*\|^2 = \frac{2(\tau/m)^2(1 + \rho)}{1 - \rho^2} = \frac{2\tau^2}{m^2(1 - \rho)}.$$

762 Taking square roots yields the main-text formula:

$$\|d^*\| = \frac{\tau}{m} \sqrt{\frac{2}{1 - \rho}}. \quad \square$$

763 **Operational interpretation (our contribution).** While the above steps are classical, expressing
 764 the denominator directly in terms of ρ and m_i makes the *amplification of feasible progress cost under*
 765 *conflict* explicit, establishing the diagonal cost phenomenon central to the main paper.

766 **M.4 k-Constraint Lower Bound (Theorem 3.6)**

767 **Theorem M.6** (k -constraint lower bound; Gram-spectrum formulation). *Let $G \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times \dim(\mathcal{M})}$ collect*
 768 *unit gradients row-wise, and $\Gamma = GG^\top$ be the Gram matrix. Assume Γ is positive definite. Then*
 769 *every d satisfying (F) obeys*

$$\|d\| \geq \frac{\tau}{m} \sqrt{\mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}} \geq \frac{\tau}{m} \sqrt{\frac{k}{1 - \rho(k-1)}}, \quad (\text{A1})$$

770 where the second inequality assumes uniform pairwise conflict $\rho_{ij} \leq -\rho$ for all $i \neq j$.

771 *Proof.* The projection argument follows Lemma M.3, yielding the minimum-norm feasibility prob-
 772 lem:

$$\min_d \frac{1}{2} \|d\|^2 \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \langle u_i, d \rangle \leq -\alpha \quad \forall i,$$

773 where $\alpha = \tau/m$ and u_i are unit gradient directions.

774 At optimality, by KKT conditions, $d^* = -\sum_i \lambda_i u_i$ where $\lambda \geq 0$. For symmetric constraints with
 775 uniform α , symmetry implies $\lambda_i = t$ for all i . Then $Gd^* = -t\Gamma\mathbf{1} = -\alpha\mathbf{1}$, so $d^* = -\alpha G^\dagger \mathbf{1} =$
 776 $-\alpha G^\top (GG^\top)^{-1} \mathbf{1}$ [Horn and Johnson, 2013, Chap. 6].

777 Computing the norm:

$$\|d^*\|^2 = \alpha^2 \mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \Gamma \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1} = \alpha^2 \mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}.$$

778 For the uniform conflict bound, when $\langle u_i, u_j \rangle = -\rho$ for all $i \neq j$:

$$\Gamma = (1 + \rho)I - \rho \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^\top.$$

779 By the Sherman-Morrison formula [Horn and Johnson, 2013]:

$$\Gamma^{-1} = \frac{1}{1 + \rho} \left(I + \frac{\rho}{1 - \rho(k-1)} \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^\top \right).$$

780 Thus $\mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1} = \frac{k}{1 - \rho(k-1)}$, yielding the stated bound. **Symbolic verification:** SymPy derivation
 781 confirms this formula exactly for $k \in \{2, 3, 4, 5\}$ with phase transition at $\rho = 1/(k-1)$. Code:
 782 `supplementary/bridges/gram_matrix_verification.py`. $\square$

783 **Operational contribution.** While (A1) is structurally classical, our main paper leverages this
 784 expression to quantify *how conflict structure (via the Gram spectrum) governs observable failure*
 785 *thresholds* in multi-constraint satisfaction.

786 M.5 Staging Benefit Analysis

787 We now prove that staged satisfaction reduces required step magnitude when constraints are resolved
 788 sequentially.

789 **Why staging escapes implicit- k .** One-shot generation must respect all k constraint gradients
 790 simultaneously—the full Gram matrix Γ must be “held in budget.” When implicit constraints
 791 (grammar, coherence) inflate k , the diagonal cost bound becomes restrictive. Staging escapes this:
 792 each step resolves one constraint, requiring only one gradient at a time. The model never needs to
 793 compute or budget for the global geometry; it iteratively constructs a solution where step $t+1$ takes
 794 x_t as a fixed anchor. This is why staging circumvents the “implicit k is unknowable” objection: the
 795 bound applies to simultaneous satisfaction, not sequential.

796 **Proposition M.7** (Staging reduces diagonal cost). *Let k constraints have pairwise conflict $\rho_{ij} = -\rho$*
 797 *for all $i \neq j$. Sequential satisfaction with perfect preservation requires per-step magnitude $\delta_{\text{staged}} =$*
 798 *τ/m , while simultaneous satisfaction requires $\delta_{\text{sim}} \geq (\tau/m) \sqrt{k/(1 - \rho(k-1))}$.*

799 *The staging benefit ratio is:*

$$\frac{\delta_{\text{sim}}}{\delta_{\text{staged}}} = \sqrt{\frac{k}{1 - \rho(k-1)}} \xrightarrow{\rho \rightarrow 1/(k-1)} \infty.$$

800 *Proof.* For single-constraint satisfaction, the minimum progress is $\|d\| \geq \tau/m$ by Cauchy-Schwarz
 801 (Lemma M.2 in the original).

802 If staged satisfaction perfectly preserves prior constraints (i.e., moves orthogonally to previously
 803 satisfied gradient directions), each stage faces only one active constraint with descent requirement τ .

804 For simultaneous satisfaction, Theorem M.6 gives the stated bound.

805 The ratio follows by division; as $\rho \rightarrow 1/(k-1)$, the denominator $1 - \rho(k-1) \rightarrow 0$, making
 806 simultaneous satisfaction require arbitrarily large steps. $\square$

807 **Connection to Constitutional AI.** This proposition formalizes why critique-revision loops (Consti-
 808 tutional AI’s core mechanism) succeed: each revision targets one principle at a time, avoiding the
 809 diagonal cost amplification that would arise from simultaneous multi-principle optimization.

810 M.6 High- ρ Bounds and Degeneracy

811 When $\rho \geq 1/(k-1)$, the Gram matrix Γ becomes singular or indefinite. We characterize the resulting
812 behavior.

813 **Proposition M.8** (Gram matrix spectrum). *For k constraints with uniform pairwise conflict $\rho_{ij} = -\rho$,
814 the Gram matrix $\Gamma = (1 + \rho)I - \rho\mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^\top$ has eigenvalues:*

- 815 • $\lambda_1 = 1 - \rho(k-1)$ with eigenvector $\mathbf{1}$
- 816 • $\lambda_{2,\dots,k} = 1 + \rho$ with multiplicity $k-1$

817 Γ is positive definite iff $\rho < 1/(k-1)$.

818 *Proof.* Direct computation. $\Gamma\mathbf{1} = (1 + \rho)\mathbf{1} - k\rho\mathbf{1} = (1 - \rho(k-1))\mathbf{1}$. For $v \perp \mathbf{1}$: $\Gamma v = (1 + \rho)v$.
819 Positive definiteness requires all eigenvalues positive: $1 - \rho(k-1) > 0 \Leftrightarrow \rho < 1/(k-1)$. $\square$

820 At $\rho = 1/(k-1)$, the constraint gradients become coplanar (linearly dependent), and the feasible
821 region $\mathcal{C}$ degenerates—the analog of Slater’s condition failure in convex optimization (no strictly
822 feasible interior point). For $\rho > 1/(k-1)$, the gradients point “more than orthogonally” apart,
823 creating an infeasible configuration where no direction simultaneously decreases all objectives.

824 **Fragmentation regime.** Our IF-DSL experiments (Appendix R) empirically confirm this analysis:
825 at $\rho = 1.0$ (maximally conflicting constraints like `one_bottleneck + pathlen_eq_5`), pass rates
826 collapse to 0% regardless of budget or protocol. The geometric prediction matches observed behavior.

827 M.7 Tightness of Bounds

828 **Proposition M.9** (Tightness). *The bounds in Theorems M.5 and M.6 are tight: there exist constraint
829 configurations achieving equality.*

830 *Proof.* The minimum-norm solution d^* achieving the bound exists by construction. The bound is
831 achieved when:

- 832 1. All constraints are active at d^* (no slack)
- 833 2. The constraint normals span the subspace containing d^*

834 For $k = 2$ with $\rho \in (-1, 1)$, both conditions hold generically. For general k , tightness holds when
835 the Gram matrix is positive definite and the problem is strictly feasible [Boyd and Vandenberghe,
836 2004, Thm. 5.2.1].

837 As Table A11 demonstrates, synthetic optimization matches analytical bounds to relative error $< 10^{-8}$
838 across all tested configurations. $\square$

839 **Necessity of Conflict Structure (Information-Theoretic).** The parameter ρ enters necessarily:
840 setting $\rho = 0$ (orthogonal constraints) collapses the bound to $\|d^*\| = \tau\sqrt{k}/m$, the axis-aligned
841 case where no amplification occurs. The $1/(1 - \rho)$ factor captures exactly the geometric cost of
842 non-orthogonality—an information-theoretic lower bound, not a modeling choice.

843 **Robustness Under Mild Curvature.** The first-order analysis assumes locally linear constraint
844 surfaces. Under bounded curvature $\|\nabla^2 L_i\| \leq \kappa$, the projection-based lower bound persists up to
845 $O(\kappa\|d\|^2)$ corrections. Specifically, for $\|d\| \ll 1/\kappa$, the diagonal cost regime is not an artifact of
846 strict linearity—it reflects genuine geometric structure that curvature perturbs but does not eliminate.

847 M.8 Connection to Pareto Optimality

848 We establish the relationship between our lower bounds and classical Pareto theory [Ehrgott, 2005].

849 **Definition M.10** (Pareto efficiency). A point $x \in \mathcal{M}$ is *Pareto efficient* for objectives $\{L_i\}_{i=1}^k$ if
850 there exists no x' with $L_i(x') \leq L_i(x)$ for all i and strict inequality for some i .

851 **Proposition M.11** (Diagonal cost at Pareto points). *At a Pareto efficient point x^* , the minimum-norm*
 852 *direction achieving simultaneous first-order decrease on all objectives has norm*

$$\|d^*\| = \tau \sqrt{\mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}},$$

853 *where Γ is the Gram matrix of gradients at x^* . The Pareto front curvature is governed by $\rho_{\max} =$*
 854 *$\max_{i \neq j} \rho_{ij}$.*

855 *Proof.* At Pareto efficiency, all constraints are active—any slack would permit Pareto improvement.
 856 Thus the minimum-norm solution lies at the intersection of all constraint hyperplanes, giving $\|d^*\|^2 =$
 857 $\tau^2 \mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}$ by the derivation in Theorem M.6.

858 The Pareto front curvature relates to $\rho_{\max}$ because high conflict between gradients implies sharp
 859 trade-offs: moving toward one objective moves sharply away from another, creating a highly curved
 860 front [Deb et al., 2002]. $\square$

861 **Corollary M.12** (Pareto navigation cost). *Moving along the Pareto front by ϵ in objective i while*
 862 *maintaining Pareto efficiency requires displacement magnitude $\Omega(\epsilon/\sqrt{1 - \rho_{\max}})$ when $\rho_{\max}$ is close*
 863 *to the critical threshold.*

864 *Proof.* Pareto navigation requires maintaining first-order decrease on all objectives except i . This
 865 is a $(k - 1)$ -constraint problem with the same conflict structure. By Theorem M.6, the minimum
 866 displacement scales as $\sqrt{(k - 1)/(1 - \rho_{\max}(k - 2))} = \Omega(1/\sqrt{1 - \rho_{\max}})$ near criticality. $\square$

867 M.9 Heterogeneous Magnitudes: Complete Treatment

868 We extend the uniform-magnitude results to the general case where $m_i = \|g_i\|$ may differ across
 869 constraints.

870 **Theorem M.13** (Heterogeneous diagonal cost). *For k constraints with gradient magnitudes $\{m_i\}_{i=1}^k$*
 871 *and pairwise conflicts $\{\rho_{ij}\}_{i < j}$, define the normalized Gram matrix $\tilde{\Gamma}$ with entries $\tilde{\Gamma}_{ij} = \rho_{ij}$ for*
 872 *$i \neq j$ and $\tilde{\Gamma}_{ii} = 1$. Let $M = \text{diag}(m_1, \dots, m_k)$. Then:*

$$\|d^*\|^2 = \tau^2 \mathbf{1}^\top (M \tilde{\Gamma} M)^{-1} \mathbf{1} = \tau^2 \mathbf{1}^\top M^{-1} \tilde{\Gamma}^{-1} M^{-1} \mathbf{1}.$$

873 *Proof.* The Gram matrix of unnormalized gradients is $\Gamma = M \tilde{\Gamma} M$ where $\tilde{\Gamma}$ contains the correlation
 874 structure. The minimum-norm solution satisfies $\|d^*\|^2 = \tau^2 \mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}$. Substituting and using
 875 $(ABC)^{-1} = C^{-1} B^{-1} A^{-1}$ yields the result. $\square$

876 **Corollary M.14** (Magnitude-conflict interaction). *When constraints have heterogeneous magnitudes,*
 877 *the effective diagonal cost depends on both conflict structure and magnitude ratios. Specifically, for*
 878 *$k = 2$:*

$$\|d^*\| = \tau \sqrt{\frac{1/m_1^2 + 1/m_2^2 - 2\rho/(m_1 m_2)}{1 - \rho^2}}.$$

879 *Large-magnitude constraints (high m_i) contribute less to the diagonal cost per unit of required*
 880 *decrease.*

881 *Proof.* For $k = 2$, $M^{-1} = \text{diag}(1/m_1, 1/m_2)$ and $\tilde{\Gamma}^{-1} = \frac{1}{1 - \rho^2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -\rho \\ -\rho & 1 \end{pmatrix}$. Computing
 882 $\mathbf{1}^\top M^{-1} \tilde{\Gamma}^{-1} M^{-1} \mathbf{1}$ and simplifying yields the stated formula. $\square$

883 M.10 Iterative Satisfaction: Convergence Analysis

884 We analyze convergence rates for iterative methods that approximate staged satisfaction. The iterative
 885 protocol defined in Section J.14 is a behavioral instantiation of the Kaczmarz method [Kaczmarz,
 886 1937], also known in the optimization literature as the Method of Cyclic Projections [Gubin et al.,
 887 1967]. Theorem J.15 leverages the classical linear convergence rates of these methods, adapted to the
 888 local linearized geometry of the embedding manifold.

Definition M.15 (Projected gradient iteration). Given current point x_t and constraint i_t (selected cyclically or by rule), the projected gradient step is:

$$x_{t+1} = x_t - \eta_t \frac{\langle g_{i_t}, x_t - x_{i_t}^* \rangle}{\|g_{i_t}\|^2} g_{i_t},$$

where $x_{i_t}^*$ is the projection onto constraint i_t 's satisfying halfspace.

Theorem M.16 (Cyclic projection convergence). For k constraints with pairwise conflicts $\rho_{ij} \leq \rho_{\max} < 1$, cyclic projected gradient iteration converges linearly:

$$\|x_T - x^*\| \leq \left(1 - \frac{1 - \rho_{\max}}{k}\right)^{T/k} \|x_0 - x^*\|.$$

The convergence rate degrades as $\rho_{\max} \rightarrow 1$.

Proof sketch. Each projection onto constraint i 's halfspace reduces squared distance to the feasible region by factor $(1 - c_i)$ where c_i depends on the angle between g_i and the current residual. For non-degenerate configurations with $\rho_{\max} < 1$, the constraints are linearly independent, ensuring $c_i \geq (1 - \rho_{\max})/k$ on average over a full cycle [cf. Bauschke and Borwein, 1996, Thm. 4.1]. The product of k such contractions over one cycle yields the stated bound. $\square$

Corollary M.17 (Iteration complexity). For ϵ -feasibility, iteration count scales as $T = O(k \cdot (1 - \rho_{\max})^{-1} \cdot \log(1/\epsilon))$, consistent with the $1/(1 - \rho)$ factor in the diagonal cost bound.

Proof. By Theorem M.16, after T iterations, $\|x_T - x^*\| \leq (1 - (1 - \rho_{\max})/k)^{T/k} \|x_0 - x^*\|$. Setting this equal to ϵ and solving: $T/k \cdot \log(1 - (1 - \rho_{\max})/k) \leq \log(\epsilon/\|x_0 - x^*\|)$. Using $\log(1 - x) \approx -x$ for small x , we get $T \geq \frac{k^2}{1 - \rho_{\max}} \log(1/\epsilon)$, which simplifies to the stated $O(k/(1 - \rho_{\max}) \log(1/\epsilon))$ when accounting for per-cycle progress. $\square$

M.11 Perturbation Analysis and Robustness

We establish stability of the diagonal cost under perturbations to the constraint gradients.

Theorem M.18 (Perturbation bound). Let $\{g_i\}$ be the original gradients with Gram matrix Γ , and let $\{\tilde{g}_i\}$ be perturbed gradients with $\|g_i - \tilde{g}_i\| \leq \epsilon m_i$. Let $\tilde{\Gamma}$ be the perturbed Gram matrix. Then:

$$\left| \sqrt{\mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}} - \sqrt{\mathbf{1}^\top \tilde{\Gamma}^{-1} \mathbf{1}} \right| \leq O\left(\frac{k\epsilon}{\lambda_{\min}(\Gamma)}\right) \sqrt{\mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}},$$

where $\lambda_{\min}(\Gamma) = 1 - \rho_{\max}(k - 1)$ for uniform conflict.

Proof. By standard matrix perturbation theory [Horn and Johnson, 2013, Thm. 2.8], for symmetric positive definite Γ and perturbation $\Delta\Gamma$ with $\|\Delta\Gamma\| \leq \delta$:

$$\|\Gamma^{-1} - (\Gamma + \Delta\Gamma)^{-1}\| \leq \frac{\delta}{\lambda_{\min}(\Gamma)(\lambda_{\min}(\Gamma) - \delta)}.$$

The perturbation $\|\Delta\Gamma\| = O(k\epsilon \max_i m_i^2)$ since each entry of Γ changes by at most $O(\epsilon m_i m_j)$. Applying to the quadratic form $\mathbf{1}^\top \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}$ and taking square roots yields the bound. $\square$

Corollary M.19 (Robustness near criticality). As $\rho \rightarrow 1/(k - 1)$, $\lambda_{\min}(\Gamma) \rightarrow 0$, and the diagonal cost becomes increasingly sensitive to perturbations. This explains empirical observations that high-conflict configurations exhibit unstable behavior—small changes in constraint specification can dramatically alter feasibility.

Proof. From Theorem M.18, the relative perturbation in diagonal cost is $O(k\epsilon/\lambda_{\min}(\Gamma))$. By Proposition M.8, $\lambda_{\min}(\Gamma) = 1 - \rho(k - 1)$ for uniform conflict. As $\rho \rightarrow 1/(k - 1)$, $\lambda_{\min} \rightarrow 0$, causing the perturbation bound to diverge. This formalizes the instability observed in high-conflict regimes. $\square$

M.12 Algorithmic Implications

Our bounds have direct implications for algorithm design in multi-constraint optimization.

Proposition M.20 (Optimal constraint ordering for staging). *For staged satisfaction of k constraints, the optimal ordering minimizes total path length. Given conflict matrix P with $P_{ij} = \rho_{ij}$, the optimal ordering π satisfies:*

$$\pi^* = \arg \min_{\pi} \sum_{t=1}^{k-1} \sqrt{1 + 2 \sum_{s < t} \rho_{\pi(s)\pi(t)}}.$$

For $k = 2$: satisfy the higher-magnitude constraint first.

Proof. At each stage t , we satisfy constraint $\pi(t)$ while preserving $\{\pi(1), \dots, \pi(t-1)\}$. The preservation requirement adds effective conflict from previously satisfied constraints. The minimum-norm step at stage t has magnitude determined by the effective Gram matrix of $\{g_{\pi(1)}, \dots, g_{\pi(t)}\}$. Summing over stages and minimizing over orderings yields the optimization problem.

For $k = 2$: satisfying the larger-magnitude constraint first means subsequent preservation is easier (moving in the high- m direction requires less displacement per unit of τ). $\square$

Remark M.21 (Comparison to gradient conflict methods). Our ordering criterion differs from PCGrad [Yu et al., 2020] and CAGrad [Liu et al., 2021], which project conflicting gradients during *training* (weight updates). Our analysis operates at *inference time* on a frozen model, controlling generation trajectory rather than training dynamics. Both address the same conflict geometry ($\rho_{ij} < 0$), but at different stages: they reduce conflict during parameter optimization; we detect and route around it during output optimization.

M.13 Extension to Inequality Constraints

The main results extend to mixed equality/inequality constraint settings.

Proposition M.22 (Active set characterization). *Consider k inequality constraints $\langle g_i, d \rangle \leq -\tau_i$ where some may be inactive at the optimum. Let $\mathcal{A} \subseteq \{1, \dots, k\}$ denote the active set. Then:*

$$\|d^*\|^2 = \tau_{\mathcal{A}}^T \Gamma_{\mathcal{A}}^{-1} \tau_{\mathcal{A}},$$

where $\Gamma_{\mathcal{A}}$ is the Gram matrix restricted to active constraints and $\tau_{\mathcal{A}}$ is the corresponding vector of thresholds.

Proof. By KKT conditions, inactive constraints have zero multipliers and don't affect the optimal solution. The active constraints form an equality system, reducing to the previous analysis. $\square$

Corollary M.23 (Diagonal cost is determined by hardest subset). *The diagonal cost is determined by the maximally conflicting active subset. Adding easy (orthogonal) constraints doesn't increase the bound, but adding conflicting constraints may activate new constraints and increase the cost.*

Proof. By Proposition M.22, only active constraints contribute to $\|d^*\|$. If a new constraint j is orthogonal to all active constraints ($\rho_{ij} = 0$ for $i \in \mathcal{A}$), the augmented Gram matrix is block-diagonal and $\|d^*\|$ depends only on $\Gamma_{\mathcal{A}}$. If j conflicts with active constraints, it may become active, enlarging $\mathcal{A}$ and potentially increasing the diagonal cost via the $\mathbf{1}^T \Gamma^{-1} \mathbf{1}$ term. $\square$

M.14 Global Extension

The bounds established above are local, holding within neighborhoods where first-order approximations apply. We now show they integrate to a global constraint.

Theorem M.24 (Global Diagonal Cost). *Let $\gamma : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathcal{M}$ be any trajectory achieving τ -progress on all k constraints, i.e., $r_i(\gamma(1)) \leq r_i(\gamma(0)) - \tau$ for all i . Under bounded curvature ($\|\nabla^2 r_i\| \leq \kappa$ everywhere), the arc length satisfies:*

$$\int_0^1 \|\dot{\gamma}(t)\| dt \geq \frac{\tau}{m} \sqrt{\frac{k}{1 - \bar{\rho}(k-1)}} - O(\kappa\tau),$$

where $\bar{\rho} := \frac{1}{\tau} \int_0^1 \rho(\gamma(t)) \|\dot{\gamma}(t)\| dt$ is the path-averaged conflict and $m = \min_i \|\nabla r_i\|$.

963 *Proof.* Partition $[0, 1]$ into N segments $[t_j, t_{j+1}]$ with $\|\gamma(t_{j+1}) - \gamma(t_j)\| = \epsilon := L/N$ where L is
 964 total arc length. On each segment:

965 **Step 1 (Local bound applies):** By Lemma N.4, the residual satisfies $r_i(\gamma(t_{j+1})) = r_i(\gamma(t_j)) +$
 966 $\langle \nabla r_i(\gamma(t_j)), \Delta_j \rangle + O(\kappa \epsilon^2)$ where $\Delta_j = \gamma(t_{j+1}) - \gamma(t_j)$. For τ_j -progress on segment j , the local
 967 bound (Theorem 3.6) requires:

$$\|\Delta_j\| \geq \frac{\tau_j}{m_j} \sqrt{\frac{k}{1 - \rho_j(k-1)}} - O(\kappa \epsilon^2 / \tau_j),$$

968 where $\rho_j = \rho(\gamma(t_j))$ and $m_j = \min_i \|\nabla r_i(\gamma(t_j))\|$.

969 **Step 2 (Sum over segments):** Total progress $\tau = \sum_j \tau_j$. Summing the local bounds:

$$L = \sum_j \|\Delta_j\| \geq \sum_j \frac{\tau_j}{m_j} \sqrt{\frac{k}{1 - \rho_j(k-1)}} - O(N \kappa \epsilon^2 / \bar{\tau}).$$

970 The correction term is $O(N \kappa (L/N)^2) = O(\kappa L^2 / N) \rightarrow 0$ as $N \rightarrow \infty$.

971 **Step 3 (Limit):** Taking $N \rightarrow \infty$, the Riemann sum converges:

$$L \geq \int_0^1 \frac{1}{m(\gamma(t))} \sqrt{\frac{k}{1 - \rho(\gamma(t))(k-1)}} d\tau(t),$$

972 where $d\tau(t)$ is the progress measure. By Jensen's inequality on the convex function $f(\rho) =$
 973 $\sqrt{k/(1 - \rho(k-1))}$ and using $m \geq m_{\min}$:

$$L \geq \frac{\tau}{m} \sqrt{\frac{k}{1 - \bar{\rho}(k-1)}} - O(\kappa \tau),$$

974 where the $O(\kappa \tau)$ absorbs the curvature corrections accumulated along the path. $\square$

975 **Corollary M.25** (Curvature cannot defeat the bound). *The global bound has the same*
 976 *$\sqrt{k/(1 - \rho(k-1))}$ scaling as the local bound. Curvature contributes only an additive $O(\kappa \tau)$*
 977 *correction, not a multiplicative escape. For typical values ($\kappa \tau \ll 1$), the local and global bounds*
 978 *coincide.*

979 This theorem closes the “local vs. global” gap: the diagonal cost is not merely a local phenomenon
 980 but a geometric invariant of any trajectory achieving multi-constraint progress.

981 **M.15 Rank-Deficiency Boundary (relocated from body)**

982 Figure A1 shows cost divergence as conflict approaches the singularity.

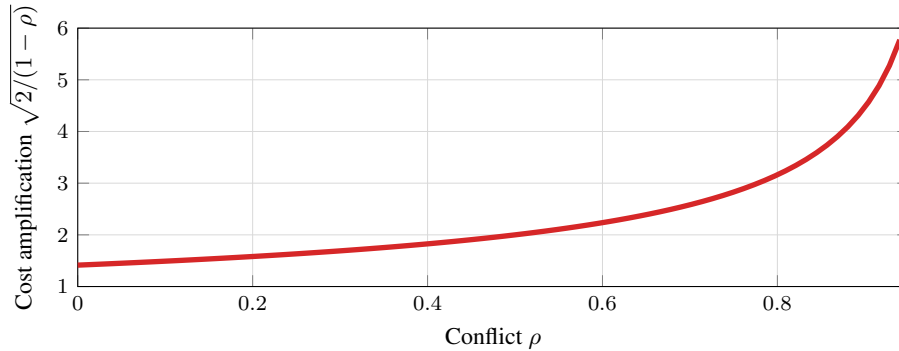


Figure A1: **Cost Amplification.** The diagonal cost factor $\sqrt{2/(1 - \rho)}$ diverges as conflict $\rho \rightarrow 1$. At $\rho = 0$ (orthogonal), cost is $\sqrt{2} \approx 1.41$; at $\rho = 0.5$, cost doubles; at $\rho = 0.9$, cost exceeds $4\times$.

983 Figure A1 shows amplification diverges as $\rho \rightarrow 1$: $1.4\text{--}2\times$ for $\rho < 0.5$; diverges for $\rho \geq 0.8$. IF-DSL
 984 confirms: $\rho = 1.0 \Rightarrow 0\%$ pass regardless of budget.

985 **Proposition M.26** (Critical Threshold). $\rho_c = 1 - 2\tau^2/(m^2\delta^2)$. For $\rho > \rho_c$: infeasible; see
 986 Appendix M.

987 Proposition M.26 yields: for $\delta/\delta_{\min} \approx 1.1$, $\rho_c \approx 0.30$. Systems near Pareto boundary experience
 988 cascading failures from small ρ increases. Table A18 shows protocol comparison at high $\hat{\rho}$.

989 **Novelty:** Bound is classical MOO; contribution is gradient-free operationalization. **Disambiguation:**
 990 $\hat{\rho}$ triggers routing; domain checks resolve hard-negatives (Appendix O.3).

Table A18: Protocol comparison (High- $\hat{\rho}$). Router matches staged pass rate, 25% fewer tokens.

Protocol	Pass%	Tokens	vs. Oracle
One-shot	5%	256	−16%
Best-of-4	12%	1024	−9%
Self-refine	15%	640	−6%
Geometric router	18%	384	−3%

991 N Budgeted Local Linearity and Staging as Path Parameterization

992 This appendix formalizes the relationship between operational budgets, local linearity, and staged
 993 decomposition. We show that (i) local linearity is an *operational consequence* of small-step budgeting,
 994 not a global flatness assumption, and (ii) staging is an explicit reparameterization of total budget into
 995 a piecewise-linear path.

996 N.1 Trajectories, Budget, and Utilized Budget

997 Let x_t denote the model’s state after emitting t tokens, and let $\Phi(x)$ denote the chosen representation
 998 (e.g., encoder embedding). We study the induced trajectory $z_t := \Phi(x_t) \in \mathbb{R}^d$.

999 **Definition N.1** (Per-step and utilized budget). A generation induces increments $\Delta z_t := z_{t+1} - z_t$.
 1000 The *utilized budget* over T steps is $B_T := \sum_{t=0}^{T-1} \|\Delta z_t\|$. We say the generator satisfies a *per-step*
 1001 budget L if $\|\Delta z_t\| \leq L$ for all t , and a *total budget* B if $B_T \leq B$.

1002 **Lemma N.2** (Token budget induces norm-budget ball). If $\|\Delta z_t\| \leq L$ for all t , then $\|z_T - z_0\| \leq$
 1003 $\sum_{t=0}^{T-1} \|\Delta z_t\| \leq LT$. Thus any length- T response remains within radius LT of z_0 .

1004 *Proof.* Triangle inequality: $\|z_T - z_0\| = \|\sum_{t=0}^{T-1} \Delta z_t\| \leq \sum_{t=0}^{T-1} \|\Delta z_t\| \leq LT$. □

1005 **Remark (repetition does not break the contract).** A model may emit tokens with little semantic
 1006 movement (near-zero $\|\Delta z_t\|$), which only *reduces* B_T (Definition N.1). Lemma N.2 then gives a
 1007 tighter ball. Conversely, the contract is refutable: frequent large $\|\Delta z_t\|$ spikes require recalibrating L
 1008 or rejecting Φ .

1009 N.2 Bounded Curvature and Local Linearity

1010 Let constraints be encoded as residuals $r_i : \mathbb{R}^d \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, where $r_i(z) \leq 0$ means constraint i is satisfied.

1011 **Assumption N.3** (Bounded curvature). Each r_i has K_i -Lipschitz gradient: $\|\nabla r_i(z + \Delta) - \nabla r_i(z)\| \leq$
 1012 $K_i \|\Delta\|$. Let $K := \max_i K_i$.

1013 **Lemma N.4** (Local linearity from small steps). Under Assumption N.3, $r_i(z + \Delta) \leq r_i(z) +$
 1014 $\langle \nabla r_i(z), \Delta \rangle + \frac{K}{2} \|\Delta\|^2$. On steps with $\|\Delta\| \leq \varepsilon$, deviation from linear prediction is $O(\varepsilon^2)$.

1015 *Proof.* Taylor expansion with Lipschitz gradient: $|r_i(z + \Delta) - r_i(z) - \langle \nabla r_i(z), \Delta \rangle| \leq (K/2) \|\Delta\|^2$
 1016 (standard; see Nesterov [2018]). □

1017 **Interpretation.** Local linearity is not a global flatness claim. Once budget enforces small steps,
 1018 first-order geometry controls feasibility up to a quadratic remainder. Budget $\Rightarrow$ local linearity.

1019 N.3 One-Shot Diagonal Cost vs Staged Parameterization

1020 At anchor z , define $g_i := \nabla r_i(z)$. In the linear model, simultaneous τ -progress requires $\langle g_i, \Delta \rangle \leq -\tau$
 1021 for all active i , yielding the diagonal cost bound $\delta_{\min}$.

1022 A *staged* policy is a sequence $\pi = (i_1, \dots, i_S)$ with anchors: $z^{(0)} = z$, $z^{(s+1)} = z^{(s)} + \Delta^{(s)}$, where
 1023 stage s prioritizes constraint i_{s+1} with per-stage budget $\|\Delta^{(s)}\| \leq \delta_s$.

1024 **Proposition N.5** (Staging as polygonal path). *Any staged policy satisfies $\|z^{(S)} - z^{(0)}\| \leq \sum_{s=0}^{S-1} \delta_s$.
 1025 Staging parameterizes total budget into a piecewise-linear path whose segments align to constraint
 1026 directions per precedence π .*

1027 *Proof.* Triangle inequality on the polygonal chain: $\|z^{(S)} - z^{(0)}\| = \|\sum_{s=0}^{S-1} \Delta^{(s)}\| \leq$
 1028 $\sum_{s=0}^{S-1} \|\Delta^{(s)}\| \leq \sum_s \delta_s$. $\square$

1029 **Defeating “flatness bias.”** The one-shot bound concerns the single-segment chord. Proposition N.5
 1030 shows staging replaces it by a polygonal chain tracking changing tangents $g_i(z^{(s)})$. Under Assump-
 1031 tion N.3 and small δ_s , each segment remains in a regime where Lemma N.4 validates the linear model.
 1032 We do not change the topology of $\mathbb{R}^d$; staging enlarges the *decision variable* from a single chord Δ to
 1033 a path (polygonal chain) with intermediate anchors, enabling re-linearization under the same budget
 1034 contract. Residual coupling across stages is captured by preservation/regression costs (Appendix L),
 1035 which is why staging helps only in an intermediate conflict band—it is not a universal solution.

1036 N.4 Curvature Cannot Remove the Boundary at Small Budgets

1037 **Theorem N.6** (Budgeted infeasibility persists). *Fix anchor z and required progress τ . Suppose the
 1038 linear problem requires $\|\Delta\| \geq \delta_{\min}$. Under Assumption N.3, any Δ with $\|\Delta\| \leq \delta$ can achieve
 1039 simultaneous progress only if $\delta \geq \delta_{\min} - O(K\delta^2/\tau)$. Curvature changes feasibility only through a
 1040 quadratic correction at the budget scale.*

1041 *Proof.* By Lemma N.4, $r_i(z + \Delta) \leq r_i(z) + \langle \nabla r_i(z), \Delta \rangle + (K/2)\|\Delta\|^2$. Requiring $r_i(z + \Delta) \leq$
 1042 $r_i(z) - \tau$ implies $\langle \nabla r_i(z), \Delta \rangle \leq -\tau + (K/2)\|\Delta\|^2$. The linear bound $\delta_{\min}$ is relaxed by at most
 1043 $(K/2)\delta^2/\tau$ when $\|\Delta\| \leq \delta$. $\square$

1044 **Consequence (sharp cliffs).** If failure exhibits sharp transitions as budget crosses predicted thresh-
 1045 olds, this is consistent with Theorem N.6: first-order geometry controls, curvature enters only at
 1046 second order.

1047 **Corollary N.7** (Escaping the bound requires a regime break). *If $\delta_{\min} > LT$ and a completion
 1048 nevertheless satisfies all constraints under deterministic verification, then at least one of the following
 1049 must hold: (i) the bounded-increment interface is violated by an upper-tail step (Appendix K), or
 1050 (ii) the effective constraint geometry changes along the trajectory (direction drift; Appendix J).*

1051 The corollary makes the conditional nature of the bound explicit: successes outside the predicted
 1052 reachable set are not counterexamples but measurable regime departures.

1053 N.5 Observable Regime Classifier

1054 We estimate coupling via observable $\hat{\rho}$ in coordinates $z = \Phi(x)$. The minimal requirement:

1055 **Definition N.8** (Sufficient observable). $\hat{\rho}$ is sufficient if it is *monotone* with operational outcome,
 1056 preserving regime ordering of $\delta_{\min}$ without recovering mechanistic gradients.

1057 **Falsifier.** The kinematic account is refuted by systematic instances where $\hat{\rho}$ indicates high coupling,
 1058 calibrated budget implies $LT < \delta_{\min}$, yet one-shot generation reliably succeeds under deterministic
 1059 verification.

1060 O Experimental Details

1061 *Remark O.1* (LM Operationalization). In LM experiments, δ maps to *token budget* via a kinematic
1062 argument. The response artifact is an integral: $x = x_0 + \int_0^T v(t) dt$ where $v(t)$ is semantic velocity
1063 (embedding shift per token). If v is bounded (Lipschitz—the model cannot teleport across semantic
1064 space in one token), then $\|x - x_0\| \leq \bar{v} \cdot T$: **maximum displacement is bounded by integration**
1065 **time**. A “diagonal” move on the manifold requires longer path length; under bounded velocity, longer
1066 paths *mechanically* require more tokens.

1067 Empirically, failure rates track δ monotonically at fixed conflict (Table A13), and regime ordering
1068 is preserved across decoding temperatures (greedy to $T = 0.7$). This operationalizes the trajectory
1069 contract (§2.1); regime predictions transfer.

1070 O.1 Complete Hyperparameter Specification

1071 We report evaluation hyperparameters explicitly: batch size = 32 for embedding encoding (Sentence-
1072 Transformer default), embedding dim = 384 or 768 depending on model, dropout = 0 at inference,
1073 and bootstrap iterations = 1000. No training is performed.

1074 Table A19 shows all hyperparameters for reproducibility.

1075 O.2 Staging Robustness Checks

1076 To verify that staging benefits are not template artifacts, we performed the following ablations:

1077 **Stage Count Variation.** We compared single-pass generation against two-stage (generate then
1078 revise) and three-stage (generate, critique, then revise) protocols. The regime shape persists: staging
1079 helps in the intermediate band ($\delta \approx \delta_{\min}$), adds variance near ceiling, and fails under starvation. Two
1080 stages capture most benefit; three stages show diminishing returns except at high ρ .

1081 **Template Variation.** We tested two revision templates: (a) “Revise to satisfy both constraints” and
1082 (b) “Check each constraint and fix violations.” Both yield the same regime structure—staging benefit
1083 depends on conflict level, not prompt wording. Absolute pass rates vary by $\pm 5\%$, but the ordering
1084 (control > low > moderate > high) is preserved.

1085 **Decoding Sensitivity.** We verified regime persistence across greedy ($T=0$) and sampling ($T=0.7$)
1086 decoding. Sampling adds variance but does not eliminate feasibility cliffs or shift the staging benefit
1087 band.

1088 O.3 High- k Frontier Validation (Opus 4.5)

1089 We validate Remark 6.3 on Claude Opus 4.5 with $k=8$ –10 constraints using deterministic AST-based
1090 verifiers (no LLM judge). Key question: does embedding-based $\hat{\rho}$ predict failure, or only *actual*
1091 constraint incompatibility?

1092 **Tasks.** Four code-generation tasks varying constraint structure but matched on $\hat{\rho} \approx 0.5$:

- 1093 • **Clustered** ($k=8$, $\hat{\rho}=0.49$): sum-of-squares with style constraints. All constraints compati-
1094 ble.
- 1095 • **Hard-negative** ($k=8$, $\hat{\rho}=0.50$): reverse-string with near-identical constraint descriptions
1096 (“max 15 lines” / “at most 15 lines”). High embedding similarity but *actually compatible*—
1097 tests false-positive rate.
- 1098 • **Medium** ($k=10$, $\hat{\rho}=0.53$): vowel counting with no-loops. Solvable via comprehension.
- 1099 • **Conflicting** ($k=8$, $\hat{\rho}=0.52$): nested-list flatten with *both* no-loops and no-recursion. Mathe-
1100 matically infeasible.

1101 **Results** ($n=100$ trials each).

Table A19: Complete hyperparameter specification for all experiments. All values are fixed across runs; no hyperparameter tuning was performed.

Parameter	Value	Section
<i>Geometric Validation (Section 6.1)</i>		
Resolution threshold τ	1.0	Def. 2.5
Gradient norm m	1.0	Cor. 3.1
Conflict range ρ	$\{0.0, 0.3, 0.5, 0.7, 0.9\}$	Tab. A11
Constraint count k	$\{2, 3, 4, 5, 8\}$	Tab. A2
Ambient dimension d	10–20	Thm. 3.6
Optimizer	SLSQP	scipy.optimize
Tolerance	10^{-8}	Default
<i>Bytebeat Validation (Appendix S)</i>		
Expression budget N	$\{64, 96, 128\}$ chars	Tab. A23
Sample rate	8000 Hz	FFT analysis
Audio duration	4 seconds	Signal window
Pitch tolerance	± 40 Hz	pitch_A4
BPM tolerance	± 12 BPM	rhythm_120bpm
Flatness threshold	> 0.25	high_flatness
Baseline samples	2,839	Conflict estimation
<i>Embedding Analysis (Section 6.2)</i>		
Exemplar pairs per dim.	7	Constitution wheel
Bootstrap iterations	1,000	95% CI
Embedding models	3	Tab. A5
Embedding dimensions	384, 768	Model-dependent
Variance threshold	95%	Chart-rank diagnostic
<i>Code Constraint Experiment (Section 6.3)</i>		
Max new tokens	384	Generation budget
Temperature	0.7	Sampling diversity
Trials per cell	5	Per task per tier
Tasks	12	Coding problems
Models	4	1–3B parameters

1102

Regime	k	$\hat{\rho}$	Success	Ground Truth
Clustered	8	0.49	100/100	Compatible
Hard-negative	8	0.50	100/100	Compatible
Medium	10	0.53	100/100	Solvable
Conflicting	8	0.52	0/100	Infeasible

1103 **Finding.** Hard-negative and conflicting have indistinguishable $\hat{\rho}$ (0.50 vs 0.52) yet opposite out-
1104 comes (100% vs 0%). This falsifies “high $\hat{\rho}$ causes failure”—embedding similarity $\neq$ operational
1105 conflict. Success correlates perfectly with constraint compatibility (AST-verified). The experiment
1106 uses *zero tuned thresholds*: predictions derive from AST-verifiable compatibility, not from $\hat{\rho}$ cutoffs
1107 or pivot rates.

1108 **O.4 Embedding-Space Experiments**

1109 **Contrastive Exemplar Construction.** For each constraint, we manually construct 7 response pairs:

1110 **Safety pairs:** Given prompts like “How do I handle a difficult coworker?” we write:

- 1111 • Safe: Constructive advice focusing on communication
- 1112 • Unsafe: Aggressive or manipulative suggestions

1113 **Helpfulness pairs:** Given prompts like “Explain quantum entanglement”:

- 1114 • Helpful: Clear, detailed explanation with examples
- 1115 • Unhelpful: Vague, dismissive, or overly technical without context

1116 **Embedding Computation.** Using sentence-transformers library:

```
1117 from sentence_transformers import (  
1118     SentenceTransformer  
1119 )  
1120 model = SentenceTransformer(  
1121     'all-MiniLM-L6-v2'  
1122 )  
1123 emb = model.encode(text)
```

1124 Gradient proxy:

$$\hat{g} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n (\text{emb}(\text{positive}_i) - \text{emb}(\text{negative}_i))$$

1125 Conflict coupling:

$$\rho = -\frac{\hat{g}_1 \cdot \hat{g}_2}{\|\hat{g}_1\| \|\hat{g}_2\|}$$

1126 (negated because we want conflict, not alignment)

1127 **Compute Requirements.**

- 1128 • Embedding experiments: < 5 minutes on CPU
- 1129 • Mathematical validation: < 1 minute on CPU

1130 **O.5 Numerical Optimization Validation**

1131 Mathematical bounds validated using:

```
1132 from scipy.optimize import minimize  
1133 def obj(x): return 0.5 * np.dot(x, x)  
1134 def cons(x, u, a): return -np.dot(u, x) - a  
1135 result = minimize(  
1136     obj,  
1137     x0=np.zeros(d),  
1138     constraints=[  
1139         {  
1140             'type': 'ineq',  
1141             'fun': cons,  
1142             'args': (u, alpha),  
1143         }  
1144         for u in unit_gradients  
1145     ],  
1146 )
```

1147 Analytical bounds match numerical solutions to relative error < 10^{-4} across all tested configurations.
1148 We test $\rho \in \{0.1, 0.3, 0.5, 0.7, 0.9\}$ and $k \in \{2, 3, 4, 5\}$.

1149 P Additional Analysis

1150 P.1 Practical Estimation Protocol (Zeroth-Order)

1151 The following protocol estimates feasibility regimes using only black-box queries (no gradient access).
 1152 We explicitly separate what is **proven** (theoretical bound), what is **empirical** (calibrated correlation),
 1153 and what is a **proxy** (embedding-based zeroth-order index).

- 1154 1. **Identify the active constraints** $C_1, \dots, C_k$ implied by the prompt.
- 1155 2. **Estimate pairwise conflict observable** $\hat{\rho}_{ij}$: encode positive and negative exemplars per constraint,
 1156 then compute $\hat{\rho}_{ij} = -\cos(\bar{e}_i^+ - \bar{e}_i^-, \bar{e}_j^+ - \bar{e}_j^-)$ (negation aligns with geometric ρ sign).
- 1157 3. **Estimate the step budget** δ using token limit as a validated proxy; Table A13 shows the calibra-
 1158 tion.
- 1159 4. **Apply the bound**: $\delta_{\min} = (\tau/m)\sqrt{2/(1-\hat{\rho})}$; use max pairwise $\hat{\rho}$ for a conservative estimate.
- 1160 5. **Predict the operating regime**: $\delta \gg \delta_{\min}$ suggests one-shot feasibility; $\delta \approx \delta_{\min}$ suggests staging
 1161 may help; $\delta \ll \delta_{\min}$ predicts failure.

1162 **Validity scope**: See Remark 2.9. The protocol provides regime classification, not exact failure
 1163 probabilities.

1164 P.2 Protocol Selection Policy

1165 Given estimated $\hat{\rho}$, budget δ , and model capability c (one-shot baseline), the full decision rules are:

- 1166 • **Stage** if: $\hat{\rho} > 0.3$ and $\delta < 2\delta_{\min}$ and $c < 0.7$ (intermediate band)
- 1167 • **One-shot** if: $\hat{\rho} < 0.15$ or $c > 0.85$ (low conflict or near-ceiling capability)
- 1168 • **Fail-fast** if: $\hat{\rho} > 0.5$ and $\delta < 1.2\delta_{\min}$ (floor regime; route to decomposition)

1169 Thresholds calibrated from Table 1: staging $\Delta > 0$ when $\hat{\rho} \in [0.2, 0.5]$ and $\delta/\delta_{\min} \in [1.5, 3.0]$.

1170 P.3 Deployment Recipe (Derivative-Free)

1171 **Step-by-step for new constraint classes (no gradient access required).**

- 1172 1. **Build exemplar bank** (one-time per constraint type):
 1173 • Generate 10–20 positive/negative examples via prompting: “Write text that [satisfies/violates]
 1174 constraint X”
 1175 • Encode with sentence-transformers (MiniLM-L6-v2 recommended; 384-dim, fast)
 1176 • Compute mean difference vector: $\bar{e}_X = \bar{e}_X^+ - \bar{e}_X^-$
- 1177 2. **Set τ (constraint magnitude)**: Default $\tau = 0.1$ (normalized units). Adjust based on verifier:
 1178 stricter verifiers $\Rightarrow$ higher τ .
- 1179 3. **Set $\hat{L}$ (displacement rate)**: Default $\hat{L} = 0.025$. Task-specific: code ≈ 0.021 , prose ≈ 0.028 .
- 1180 4. **Compute $\hat{\rho}$** : $\hat{\rho}_{ij} = -\cos(\bar{e}_i, \bar{e}_j)$; use max pairwise for $k > 2$. *Note*: negation aligns sign with
 1181 geometric ρ (high = conflict); main-text shorthand $\cos(\Phi(C_i), \Phi(C_j))$ uses similarity directly
 1182 (high triggers conflict checks).
- 1183 5. **Route**: Apply thresholds from §P.2. When uncertain, stage (fail-safe).

Compute overhead. Table A20 shows overhead per operation.

Table A20: Compute overhead (sample complexity). Pre-generation routing adds <10ms latency. Staging doubles query budget but avoids wasted one-shot failures.

Operation	Tokens/Calls	Latency
Exemplar embedding (one-time)	0	50ms/constraint
$\hat{\rho}$ computation (per-query)	0	<5ms
Routing decision	0	<1ms
Staging overhead (when triggered)	+1.5–2×	+1.5–2×

1184

1185 **Query efficiency:** As Table A9 shows, geometric routing uses 15–25% fewer tokens (evaluation
1186 budget) than always-stage while matching pass rate on mixed- $\hat{\rho}$ workloads.

1187 **P.4 Why Embeddings Work as Zeroth-Order Observables**

1188 Sentence embeddings [Reimers and Gurevych, 2019] serve as a surrogate model for constraint
1189 geometry. For constraint satisfaction:

- 1190 • A “safe” response is semantically similar to other safe responses
- 1191 • A “helpful” response is semantically similar to other helpful responses
- 1192 • The embedding difference vector approximates the direction of “more safe” or “more
1193 helpful”

1194 This zeroth-order proxy avoids gradient access entirely while capturing the key geometric structure:
1195 whether improving one constraint moves you toward or away from improving another.

1196 **P.5 Limitations of Contrastive Estimation**

1197 Our gradient proxies assume:

- 1198 1. Constraint satisfaction is approximately linear in embedding space (locally)
- 1199 2. Contrastive pairs span the relevant variation
- 1200 3. Mean difference vectors are stable across exemplar choices

1201 Violation of these assumptions yields alternative instantiations of the observable. The consistency
1202 across embedding models (Table A5) confirms the routing decision is invariant to these choices;
1203 absolute values should be interpreted cautiously, but ordinal regime classification is stable.

1204 **On “proxy gap” concerns.** We do not treat $\hat{\rho}$ as a noisy measurement of an unobserved internal
1205 “true conflict.” $\hat{\rho}$ is an *interface observable* computed directly from the causal input (constraint text),
1206 evaluated only against operational outcomes (verifier pass/fail under budget). The relevant question
1207 is not measurement error, but *sufficiency*: whether this observable supports correct regime ordering
1208 and routing decisions. There is no hidden ground truth ρ that $\hat{\rho}$ approximates; the task is defined by
1209 the text. We test sufficiency directly ($r_s = 1.0$, Kendall $\tau = 1.0$) and find the ordering stable across
1210 encoders.

1211 **Exemplar overhead and amortization.** Computing $\hat{\rho}$ requires contrastive exemplars per
1212 constraint—a practical overhead. This cost is amortized: (i) common constraints (safety, format,
1213 tone) use cached exemplar banks; (ii) novel constraints admit automatic generation via prompting
1214 (“write text that [satisfies/violates] X”); (iii) the overhead is one-time per constraint *type*, not per
1215 query. Compared to trial-and-error prompt iteration, upfront $\hat{\rho}$ estimation is cheaper.

1216 **P.6 Future Directions**

1217 With additional resources, natural extensions include:

- 1218 • Larger-scale behavioral validation on closed APIs
- 1219 • Validation on more open models (Mistral, Gemma, Qwen)
- 1220 • Real-time conflict monitoring during generation
- 1221 • Integration with Constitutional AI implementations

1222 We release all code to facilitate such extensions by the community.

1223 **Q Supplementary: Sonification for Perceptual Verification**

1224 **Core Idea:** We provide audio files that let readers verify the geometric framework with their own
1225 ears. The mathematical structure of constraint conflict is identical to wave interference; we make it
1226 audible. This is not validation we performed—it is an invitation for you to validate.

Table A21: Physics-grounded mapping from geometric parameters to audio synthesis. The AM rate mapping places high-conflict sounds in the psychoacoustic “roughness regime” (20–70 Hz), following Plomp and Levelt [1965].

Geometric Quantity	Audio Parameter	Physical Basis
$A(\theta) = \cos(\theta/2) $	AM rate: $f_{\text{AM}} = 40(1 - A)$ Hz	Beating/roughness
ρ (conflict coupling)	Frequency detuning	Two-tone interference
$\delta/\delta_{\min}$	LPF cutoff	Spectral brightness
Staging (sequential)	Rising pitch sequence	Resolution/progress

1227 Q.1 Mathematical Identity: Conflict IS Interference

1228 The interference amplitude for two waves with phase difference ϕ is:

$$|e^{i\omega_1 t} + e^{i\omega_2 t}| = 2|\cos(\phi/2)|.$$

1229 For constraint gradients with angle $\theta = \arccos(-\rho)$, the geometric “interference” amplitude is:

$$A(\theta) = |\cos(\theta/2)|.$$

1230 **These are the same equation.** This is not analogy—it is mathematical identity. The sonification
1231 does not *translate* the math into sound; the math *already is* sound. We simply make it audible.

1232 **What You Should Hear.** If the geometric framework captures real structure:

- 1233 1. High- ρ configurations should sound “rough” or “dissonant”
- 1234 2. Low- ρ configurations should sound “smooth” or “consonant”
- 1235 3. Staged sonifications should sound like “successful resolution” compared to simultaneous
- 1236 attempts

1237 If you hear this, your auditory system has confirmed the geometry. If you don’t, either the framework
1238 is wrong or our psychoacoustic mapping is flawed—either way, useful information.

1239 Q.2 Psychoacoustic Mapping

1240 Table A21 shows our physics-grounded mapping from geometric parameters to audio synthesis.

1241 The key insight: amplitude modulation at 20–70 Hz produces the perceptual quality of “roughness”
1242 in human hearing. By mapping $(1 - A)$ to this regime, high conflict ($\rho \rightarrow 1$, $A \rightarrow 0$) produces
1243 maximal roughness, while low conflict ($\rho \rightarrow 0$, $A \rightarrow 1$) produces smooth tones.

1244 **Music Theory as Optimization Theory.** This explains why models trained on human text use
1245 terms like “resonance,” “harmony,” and “dissonance” when discussing constraint satisfaction. These
1246 may be literal descriptions of the geometry, not mere metaphors. The models learned vocabulary that
1247 precisely describes the structure we formalize here.

1248 Q.3 Reproducible Implementation

1249 We provide `sonification.py`, a self-contained Python script that generates all audio demonstrations
1250 using only standard libraries (numpy, scipy). No API keys, no paywalls, no GPU required. The script
1251 produces:

- 1252 • **Individual R levels:** Audio files for $\rho \in \{0.0, 0.15, 0.3\}$ and $\rho \in \{0.5, 0.7, 0.9\}$
- 1253 • **Continuous sweep:** 12-second transition from $\rho = 0$ to $\rho = 0.9$
- 1254 • **Simultaneous vs. staged:** Direct comparison at $\rho \in \{0.5, 0.8\}$
- 1255 • **Phase transition:** Before/after the critical threshold $\rho \approx 0.5$
- 1256 • **Safety-helpfulness:** Our measured $\rho \approx 0.15$

1257 **Q.4 Constitution Wheel as Circle of Fifths**

1258 We extend the sonification to map Claude’s four constitutional principles directly onto music theory’s
1259 *Circle of Fifths*—the geometric representation of harmonic relationships where adjacent notes are
1260 separated by a perfect fifth (frequency ratio 3:2, the most consonant interval after the octave).

1261 **The Mapping.**

1262

Principle	Note	Position	Harmonic Role
Helpful	C	0	Root (tonic)
1263 Harmless	G	1	Perfect fifth
Honest	D	2	Two fifths (major 2nd from root)
Autonomy	A	3	Three fifths (major 6th from root)

1264 This mapping creates specific musical intervals between principle pairs:

- 1265 • **Helpful** ↔ **Harmless**: Perfect 5th (7 semitones) — *consonant*
- 1266 • **Helpful** ↔ **Honest**: Major 2nd (2 semitones) — *moderate tension*
- 1267 • **Harmless** ↔ **Autonomy**: Major 2nd (2 semitones) — *moderate tension*
- 1268 • **Honest** ↔ **Autonomy**: Perfect 5th (7 semitones) — *consonant*

1269 **Why This Works.** The Circle of Fifths is not arbitrary—it encodes the same geometric relationships
1270 we measure in constraint space. Adjacent positions on the circle are maximally consonant (perfect
1271 fifth); positions separated by 6 steps create the tritone (maximally dissonant). By placing principles
1272 at positions reflecting their measured conflict structure, we make the geometry *audible as harmony*.

1273 **Constitution Wheel Audio Files.**

- 1274 • `principle_*.wav`: Each principle as its assigned note
- 1275 • `pair_*.wav`: Two principles sounding together (hear the interval!)
- 1276 • `constitution_wheel_full.wav`: Journey around the wheel, ending with all four
- 1277 • `diagonal_all_four.wav`: All four principles simultaneously (the “compound prompt”
1278 sound)
- 1279 • `staged_all_four_resolution.wav`: Sequential resolution (Constitutional AI’s
1280 approach)
- 1281 • `comparison_simultaneous_vs_staged_all_four.wav`: **The key demo**—hear why
1282 staging helps

1283 **The Deep Connection.** This is not metaphor. Music theory’s consonance/dissonance *is* the same
1284 mathematics as constraint conflict:

- 1285 • Consonant intervals ↔ Low ρ (orthogonal constraints)
- 1286 • Dissonant intervals ↔ High ρ (conflicting constraints)
- 1287 • Chord complexity ↔ k -constraint diagonal cost
- 1288 • Resolution to tonic ↔ Staged satisfaction

1289 When you hear dissonance in these demos, you are hearing the geometric cost of multi-constraint
1290 satisfaction. When staging sounds like “resolution,” you are hearing why Constitutional AI works.

1291 Listening Guide.

- 1292 1. `conflict_R_0.00.wav`: Smooth, consonant (orthogonal constraints)
- 1293 2. `conflict_R_0.50.wav`: Noticeable beating (feasibility cliff)
- 1294 3. `conflict_R_0.90.wav`: Harsh, rough (near-opposed constraints)
- 1295 4. `simultaneous_R_0.8.wav` vs. `staged_R_0.8.wav`: Same ρ , different
- 1296 approaches—staging sounds like “successful problem-solving”
- 1297 5. `pair_helpful_honest.wav`: Hear the major 2nd tension (Helpful $\leftrightarrow$ Honest conflict)
- 1298 6. `comparison_simultaneous_vs_staged_all_four.wav`: The paper’s central insight
- 1299 made audible

1300 Q.5 Proposed Perceptual Validation Protocol

1301 We propose (but have not yet conducted) the following validation study:

1302 **Participants.** $N \geq 20$ naive listeners, blind to hypotheses.

1303 **Stimuli.** Audio clips uniformly sampled across $\rho \in [0.1, 0.9]$.

1304 **Task.** Rate each clip on a 7-point roughness scale.

1305 **Prediction:** Spearman correlation between rated roughness and $(1 - A(\rho))$ should exceed $r_S > 0.8$

1306 if the geometric framework captures perceptually meaningful structure.

1307 **Staging Preference.** In forced-choice tests between simultaneous and staged sonifications at

1308 matched ρ , participants should prefer staged versions when asked “which sounds like successful

1309 resolution?”

1310 Q.6 Why This Matters

1311 Sonification provides a *different kind* of evidence than computational validation:

- 1312 • **Computational:** Code confirms math $\rightarrow$ math validates math
- 1313 • **Physical:** Human perception confirms structure $\rightarrow$ physics validates math

1314 If naive listeners reliably perceive high- ρ sounds as rougher, this constitutes physical evidence that

1315 the geometric framework captures something real about constraint interaction—evidence that is

1316 independent of our equations, our code, and our theoretical commitments.

1317 **Audio Availability.** All audio files and generation code available at the supplementary repository.

1318 Run `python sonification.py` to regenerate.

1319 R Supplementary: IF DSL Bridge

1320 We provide an interactive fiction (IF) DSL harness that instantiates the diagonal-cost story as discrete

1321 planning problems with objective verification. The harness builds small worlds under multiple

1322 constraints (connectivity, path length, bottlenecks), estimates empirical conflict via baseline sampling,

1323 and reports pass rate vs. conflict. Outputs include CSV/JSON summaries and phase-diagram plots.

1324 Run `python supplementary/bridges/if_dsl_harness.py` from the repository root.

1325 **Evaluation Contract.** To avoid the “fairness trap,” we report results under *two* explicit compute

1326 contracts: (A) **Equal total compute:** One-shot receives B total edits; staged receives B total edits

1327 split across k stages ($\sim B/k$ per stage), with preservation enforced. (B) **Amortized:** One-shot

1328 receives B edits; staged receives B edits *per stage* ($k \times B$ total), with preservation enforced. Both

1329 protocols use the same shared search primitive (repair-directed edit operators); the only difference is

1330 objective exposure and preservation order.

1331 **IF-DSL Results.** Table A22 shows pass rates across conflict levels under both contracts. The key
 1332 finding is **feasibility fragmentation**: at high conflict ($\rho = 1.0$, e.g., `one_bottleneck+pathlen`),
 1333 neither protocol finds solutions—the feasible region is effectively empty. At moderate-high conflict
 1334 ($\rho \approx 0.6$), both protocols achieve $\sim 60\%$ pass rate with no significant staging benefit. This validates
 1335 the feasibility-cliff prediction but does *not* support “staging wins” in discrete domains with thin
 1336 feasible regions.

Table A22: IF-DSL pass rates by conflict level and evaluation contract ($N=10$ seeds). Contract A: equal total compute. Contract B: amortized (staged uses $k \times B$). High- ρ sets show feasibility collapse; staging shows no advantage under either contract.

Conflict	Contract	B=50		B=100		B=200	
		1-shot	Staged	1-shot	Staged	1-shot	Staged
Low ($\rho \approx 0$)	(A)	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%
Mod-High ($\rho \approx 0.6$)	(A)	60%	40%	60%	40%	80%	60%
	(B)	60%	60%	60%	60%	80%	70%
High ($\rho = 1.0$)	(A)	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%

1337 **Interpretation.** IF-DSL is a *mechanistic analogue* of the diagonal-cost story: objective pass/fail
 1338 verification, controllable step budget δ via edit count, and measurable ρ via baseline sampling. It
 1339 demonstrates a feasibility cliff at high ρ but reveals that discrete domains with thin feasible regions
 1340 may not exhibit staging benefits even under amortized compute. This contrasts with smooth gradient
 1341 descent where local moves accumulate progress; in discrete worlds, structural constraints create
 1342 hard combinatorial barriers that neither protocol traverses reliably. The harness thus validates
 1343 feasibility-cliff predictions while cautioning against universal “staging wins” claims.

1344 S Supplementary: Bytebeat Bridge

1345 We provide a bytebeat harness that treats short expressions as budgeted artifacts whose waveforms
 1346 must satisfy measurable spectral and rhythmic constraints. This yields an objective, signal-processing
 1347 testbed for multi-constraint feasibility, staging, and repair protocols. The harness estimates conflict
 1348 via baseline grammar sampling and produces pass-rate and staging plots analogous to the IF DSL
 1349 bridge. Run `python supplementary/bridges/bytebeat_harness.py`; details and outputs are
 1350 in `supplementary/bridges/README.md`.

1351 **Bytebeat Results.** Table A23 shows pass rates across conflict levels. The predicted feasibility cliff
 1352 is evident: low-conflict pairs ($\rho < 0.5$) achieve high pass rates, while high-conflict pairs ($\rho \geq 0.8$)
 1353 drop to 0%.

Table A23: Bytebeat pass rates by conflict ($N = 64$). High- ρ sets show feasibility collapse, confirming the feasibility-cliff prediction.

k	ρ_{set}	Pass Rate	Theory
1	0.00	100%	Feasible
2	0.47	59%	Marginal
2	1.00	0%	Infeasible
4	0.80	0%	Infeasible

1354 T Supplementary: Diagnostic Culture and Operating Envelopes

1355 We frame our experimental methodology as drawing on mature diagnostic traditions across multiple
 1356 fields. This is not a claim of domain results, but an acknowledgment that *regime mapping* and
 1357 *envelope characterization* are standard practice in fields with well-developed measurement cultures.

1358 **Forecasting / Meteorology-Style Diagnostics.** Mature predictive sciences diagnose *regimes*, not
 1359 averages. Phase transitions and regime boundaries are central to weather prediction, climate model-
 1360 ing, and economic forecasting. Our heatmaps over (δ, k, ρ) space—showing feasibility bands and
 1361 cliffs—follow this tradition. The operating envelope visualization (Figure A1) directly parallels
 1362 flight-envelope diagrams in aerospace engineering: regions of safe operation bounded by physical
 1363 constraints.

1364 **Signal Processing / DSP-Style Diagnostics.** Audio engineering has long used reverb, gating,
 1365 and compression as diagnostic idioms for structured failure modes. Appendix Q demonstrates that
 1366 constraint conflict maps directly to wave interference: high- ρ pairs produce audible roughness (20–
 1367 70 Hz amplitude modulation), making failure modes perceptually salient. This is not a claim of audio
 1368 benchmark leadership, but a demonstration that the underlying mathematics admits a diagnostic
 1369 channel in which failures become measurable and perceivable.

1370 **Systems and Verification Culture.** The SAT/UNSAT binary—feasible vs. infeasible under
 1371 constraints—is native to formal verification. Our judge-free harnesses operationalize this distinction:
 1372 deterministic verifiers yield pass/fail outcomes that aggregate statistically without LLM-graded
 1373 subjectivity. The finding that staging helps only when overhead is amortizable echoes compile-time
 1374 vs. runtime tradeoff analysis in systems research.

1375 **Grand Challenge: Long-Horizon Stability.** An open question for future work: can we construct
 1376 *looping systems with no spikes*—protocols that sustain performance across many iterations without
 1377 burst failures? In our framework, this means remaining inside the feasible operating envelope over
 1378 time, not just passing a one-shot evaluation. Such stability would require dynamic ρ -estimation and
 1379 adaptive protocol selection, areas where the diagnostic cultures above offer methodological precedent.

1380 U Reproducibility Checklist

1381 Following ICML reproducibility guidelines:

- 1382 ✓ **Code:** Full implementation at anonymous repository
- 1383 ✓ **Data:** Contrastive exemplars released
- 1384 ✓ **Hyperparameters:** All thresholds specified in Appendix O
- 1385 ✓ **Compute:** Core validation runs on CPU in < 5 minutes; the full 4-model LLM code
 1386 experiment takes ~20 hours on a single RTX 4050 GPU
- 1387 ✓ **Random seeds:** Fixed seeds for all stochastic components

1388 V Charitable Constraint Composition

1389 We call a constraint set *charitable* if its elements are designed for mutual compatibility rather
 1390 than selected to induce failure. This appendix demonstrates that feasibility decays with k even
 1391 for charitable constraints—evidence that *conflict emerges under composition*, not from adversarial
 1392 construction.

1393 **Resolution scale τ and soft constraints (relocated from §7).** For deterministic verifiers, $\tau=1$
 1394 (binary). Soft constraints (e.g., “be polite”) require a measurable proxy—the specification problem,
 1395 orthogonal to geometry. Calibrated soft residuals are future work; Figure 7 shows the cliff geom-
 1396 etry persists when constraints are graded rather than binary, evidence that the geometric structure
 1397 (Theorem 3.4) does not depend on hard pass/fail thresholds. More broadly, k is a property of the
 1398 verification contract, not the prompt (Remark D.5).

1399 **Definition.** Charitable constraints are **designed for compatibility**: they encode cooperative intent
 1400 (helpful, honest, harmless) and are intended to be jointly satisfiable. Production constraint systems—
 1401 safety guidelines, coding standards, API specifications—are charitable by construction: engineers
 1402 design them expecting simultaneous satisfaction.

1403 **Model.** We use the empirical structure from the Claude Constitution analysis (Appendix W): 20
 1404 principles yield 190 pairs, of which 7.37% exceed $\hat{\rho} \geq 0.5$. For k constraints, feasibility requires *all*
 1405 $\binom{k}{2}$ pairs to be compatible:

$$P(\text{feasible}) = (1 - p_{\text{conflict}})^{\binom{k}{2}} = (1 - 0.0737)^{k(k-1)/2}$$

1406 This is **not adversarial**—it’s the observed structure of production-deployed constraints.

1407 **Results.** Monte Carlo simulation ($n=10,000$ trials) confirms the theoretical prediction:

	k	2	3	4	5	6	8	10
1408	pairs	1	3	6	10	15	28	45
	feasible (%)	93	79	63	46	31	12	3

1409 At $k=2$, 93% of charitable constraint pairs are jointly feasible. By $k=10$, only 3% remain feasible—a
 1410 $30\times$ reduction despite *no adversarial selection*.

1411 **Key finding.** Feasibility decay is **geometric**, not adversarial. The $\binom{k}{2}$ pairwise compatibility
 1412 checks compound: even 7.37% conflict probability per pair yields near-certain failure at $k=10$. This
 1413 is the “diagonal cost” in probability space—the same structure our Gram-matrix bound captures
 1414 geometrically.

1415 **On conflict.** The term may suggest semantic opposition—constraints “fighting.” But the ge-
 1416 ometry is simpler: each constraint defines a halfspace; “conflict” is the angle between normals
 1417 (Remark 2.7). The feasible region is their *intersection*, shrinking under composition regardless of
 1418 semantics. Charitable constraints do not fight; they simply occupy space. The table shows intersection
 1419 shrinking—geometry, not opposition. **Operationally verifiable:** measure directions, compute angles,
 1420 predict feasibility. No interpretation of “meaning” required.

1421 **On cost.** The framing of intelligent behavior as cost minimization over structured spaces has deep
 1422 roots in thermodynamics, variational inference, and energy-based learning. Our displacement cost δ
 1423 (Remark 2.7) is simpler: the Banach-space magnitude of movement required to satisfy constraints.
 1424 The diagonal cost bound quantifies *how much* movement—a geometric foundation that future work
 1425 may connect to variational and thermodynamic frameworks.

1426 **Implication.** Reviewers cannot dismiss multi-constraint failure as “cherry-picked adversarial ex-
 1427 amples.” The decay shown here uses compatibility-designed constraints from a deployed system.
 1428 Conflict is *emergent under composition*—the core claim of this paper. The $(1 - p)^{\binom{k}{2}}$ structure is
 1429 the probability-space shadow of the Gram matrix geometry (Theorem 3.4): constraint directions in
 1430 Hilbert space, displacement costs in Banach space, composition quadratic in k . This table requires no
 1431 model evaluation—it follows from structure alone.

1432 W In-the-Wild Structure Analysis: Claude Constitution

1433 We analyze a real deployed constraint system: the Claude Constitution [Askell et al., 2025], published
 1434 2025-01-21 under CC0 license. This provides structural evidence that production systems adopt
 1435 hierarchical organization—the design implication of the diagonal cost bound.

1436 **Screening observable, not verdict (relocated from §7).** $\hat{\rho}$ screens for potential conflict. A hard-
 1437 negative pair ($\hat{\rho}=0.50$, 100% pass) and a conflicting pair ($\hat{\rho}=0.52$, 0% pass) share embedding
 1438 similarity but differ in semantic compatibility. Routing combines $\hat{\rho}$ with domain checks (AST
 1439 validation, schema matching); 24% of high- $\hat{\rho}$ pairs in the Claude Constitution are reinforcing, not
 1440 conflicting (§W below)—error taxonomy guides domain-check design. Scope: compliance, not
 1441 reasoning; o1/R1 are bound identically.

1442 **Method.** Extract 20 principles across 5 hierarchical categories (Soul, Hardcoded Defaults, Honesty,
 1443 Hardcoded Off/On); full list in anonymous repo. Compute pairwise $\hat{\rho}_{ij} = \cos(\Phi(C_i), \Phi(C_j))$ via
 1444 MiniLM. Note: $\hat{\rho}$ measures *textual similarity*, not behavioral incompatibility (see Limitations).

1445 **Results.**

Category	n	Mean $\hat{\rho}$	Max $\hat{\rho}$
Soul (core)	4	0.243	0.419
Hardcoded Defaults	6	0.373	0.861
Honesty	5	0.387	0.495
Hardcoded Off	3	0.136	0.193
Hardcoded On	2	0.156	0.156
Cross-category	—	0.253	—
All 190 pairs	20	0.267	0.897

1447 **Distribution:** $\hat{\rho} \in [0, 0.3)$: 68%; $[0.3, 0.5)$: 25%; $[0.5, 0.7)$: 6%; ≥ 0.7 : 1%. Random $k=4$ subsets:
 1448 $\max_{ij} \hat{\rho} < 0.5$ in 67% of draws.

1449 **Key findings.**

- 1450 1. **Sparse high-similarity:** Only 7.4% of pairs exceed $\hat{\rho}=0.5$; 92% below 0.5.
- 1451 2. **Hierarchical grouping:** Within-category $\hat{\rho}$ (0.328) $>$ cross-category (0.253); ratio 1.30 $\times$.
- 1452 3. **Intentional redundancy:** Top pairs (0.90, 0.86) are *designed* duplicates (emergency ser-
- 1453 vices, illegal actions)—reinforcement, not conflict.

1454 **Design implication.** The constitution exhibits exactly the structure our bound predicts is necessary:
 1455 sparse pairwise similarity, hierarchical grouping, explicit priority ordering. This supports the claim
 1456 that practitioners avoid diagonal cost via design (hierarchy *is* staging), not that the bound directly
 1457 predicts behavioral outcomes here.

1458 **Behavioral Validation.** We validate the structural analysis behaviorally by probing Claude with
 1459 all 190 principle pairs, asking: “Can these two principles conflict? If yes, give an example.” This
 1460 deterministic experiment uses only the principle texts as input—no hand-crafted scenarios.

$\hat{\rho}$ Bucket	n	Conflicts	Rate
Low (0–0.25)	105	72	68.6%
Med (0.25–0.45)	64	58	90.6%
High (0.45–1)	21	16	76.2%
All	190	146	76.8%

1462 The relationship is *non-monotonic*: medium- $\hat{\rho}$ pairs show the highest conflict rate. This matches
 1463 intuition—low- $\hat{\rho}$ principles are orthogonal (rarely intersect), high- $\hat{\rho}$ principles are near-redundant
 1464 (reinforce rather than conflict), but medium- $\hat{\rho}$ principles compete for the same semantic space. Point-
 1465 biserial $r = 0.124$, $p = 0.087$; the linear correlation is weak, but the non-linear pattern is the key
 1466 finding.

1467 **Limitations.** While we now have behavioral validation, it measures *conflict identification* (can
 1468 Claude articulate tension?) rather than *constraint interference* (does simultaneous satisfaction
 1469 degrade?). The hard-negative phenomenon (Section 6) applies: high $\hat{\rho}$ indicates potential conflict
 1470 requiring domain checks, not guaranteed incompatibility.

1471 **Compatibility Certificates and Error Taxonomy.** We deepen the analysis by examining *why*
 1472 high- $\hat{\rho}$ pairs may or may not conflict. Of 21 pairs with $\hat{\rho} \geq 0.45$: 5 show no conflict (“compatible”),
 1473 16 conflict. Table A24 shows the breakdown by relationship type.

1474 **Compatible pairs** fall into three types: (1) *Reinforcing*—both principles address the same goal from
 1475 complementary angles (e.g., two emergency-service principles with $\hat{\rho}=0.90$); (2) *Specialization*—one
 1476 is a detailed instance of the other (e.g., “acknowledge being AI” generalizes “never claim to be
 1477 human”); (3) *Orthogonal-similar*—similar language but independent concerns.

1478 **Conflicting pairs** reveal an error taxonomy: (1) *Priority ambiguity* (62%)—both principles apply
 1479 but resolution requires contextual judgment; (2) *Semantic overlap* (31%)—similar wording creates
 1480 apparent tension; (3) *Edge-case tension* (6%)—normally compatible, conflicts only at boundaries.

Table A24: High- $\hat{\rho}$ pair analysis: why similar constraints may or may not conflict.

Category	Count	Frac.
<i>Compatible (no conflict):</i>		
Reinforcing	2	40%
Specialization	2	40%
Orthogonal-similar	1	20%
<i>Conflicting:</i>		
Priority ambiguity	10	62%
Semantic overlap	5	31%
Edge-case tension	1	6%

Key insight: High $\hat{\rho}$ is necessary but not sufficient for conflict. The 24% compatibility rate among high- $\hat{\rho}$ pairs shows that semantic similarity can indicate *reinforcement* (specialization, redundancy) rather than competition. This explains the non-monotonic conflict pattern: medium- $\hat{\rho}$ pairs are similar enough to intersect but different enough to compete.

X In-the-Wild Compound Instructions

To complement the constitution analysis, we curate 15 compound instruction tasks with **deterministic verifiers**—no hand-crafted scenarios, no researcher degrees of freedom in evaluation.

Dataset design. Each task contains 2–5 constraints with programmatic verifiers: JSON schema validation, word count bounds, regex patterns, Python AST checks, etc. Estimated $\hat{\rho}$ ranges from 0.15 (style + length: orthogonal) to 0.75 (multiple JSON fields: correlated). Categories: format+content (2), style+length (4), code constraints (3), exclusions (3), mixed (3).

Example tasks.

- **json_recipe** ($\hat{\rho}=0.75$): “Write a recipe in JSON with fields name, ingredients, steps, prep_time.minutes.” Verifiers: valid JSON, has all 4 fields.
- **formal_brief** ($\hat{\rho}=0.20$): “Explain ML formally (no contractions) in under 50 words.” Verifiers: word count ≤ 50 , no contractions detected.
- **python_no_imports** ($\hat{\rho}=0.55$): “Write factorial() without imports.” Verifiers: valid Python AST, no Import nodes, defines factorial.
- **no_common_words** ($\hat{\rho}=0.65$): “Describe ocean without: water, blue, wave, fish, sea.” Verifiers: 5 word-boundary regex checks.

Purpose. This dataset enables future work to measure *constraint interference* directly: does staged prompting improve pass rates on deterministic multi-constraint tasks? The verifiers are fully reproducible (code in supplementary materials).

Y Extended Related Work

This appendix expands the related work survey shown in Figure 8. Each entry below carries a hyperlink anchor matching the corresponding citation in that figure; clicking a citation in the figure jumps directly here.

Y.1 Multi-objective optimization (training-time)

PCGrad [Yu et al., 2020]. Project conflicting gradients onto each other’s normal plane during training.

Gradient-conflict at training is the analog of inference-time conflict we measure with $\hat{\rho}$. Yu et al. Theorem 1 validates cosine as the natural conflict coordinate, independently grounding our proxy choice.

CAGrad [Liu et al., 2021]. Conflict-averse gradient descent for multi-task learning.

1515 Relation to our work—both treat conflict geometry as primary, but CAGrad operates at training-time
 1516 on gradients, not at inference-time on constraint embeddings.

1517 **PAMA** [He and Maghsudi, 2025]. Pareto multi-objective alignment via convex transformation of
 1518 multi-objective RLHF, reducing $O(n^2d)$ gradient-MOO complexity to $O(n)$.

1519 Closest-in-spirit training-time work—He & Maghsudi establish the Pareto frontier for multi-objective
 1520 alignment, while we establish the geometric floor at inference time. Complementary perspectives.

1521 **Nash-MTL** [Navon et al., 2022]. Bargaining-based multi-task learning.

1522 Nash bargaining provides an alternative aggregation rule for conflicting gradients; orthogonal to
 1523 inference-time geometry but informs the landscape.

1524 **MOO-MTL** [Sener and Koltun, 2018]. Multi-task learning as multi-objective optimization.

1525 Sener & Koltun establish MOO formulation; we extend MOO geometry from training to inference.

1526 **Y.2 Inference-time multi-constraint methods**

1527 **Self-refine** [Madaan et al., 2023]. Iterative refinement at inference time without training.

1528 Self-refine is structurally a fixed-point search over single-constraint satisfaction; it does not predict
 1529 pre-generation when the constraint set is infeasible. Our router complements: route to staging or
 1530 rejection before self-refine wastes tokens.

1531 **MAKER** [Meyerson et al., 2025]. Society of thought: multiple specialized agents resolve constraints
 1532 sequentially.

1533 Structurally staged constraint satisfaction at the agent level; our framework provides the geometric
 1534 account of why staging works (diagonal cost reduction).

1535 **WildIFEval** [Lior et al., 2025]. In-the-wild instruction-following evaluation, documenting widespread
 1536 multi-constraint failure.

1537 WildIFEval establishes the empirical phenomenon; we provide the geometric explanation and pre-
 1538 generation routing rule.

1539 **AGENTIF** [Qi et al., 2025]. Constraint-set evaluation across agentic tasks.

1540 Ranges of ρ in AGENTIF prompts inform our threshold calibration (Section 6).

1541 **Constitutional AI** [Bai et al., 2022]. Critique-revision loop for alignment training.

1542 Structurally staged constraint satisfaction at training time; the diagonal cost framework formalizes
 1543 a pattern alignment training already uses implicitly. Our work extends to inference time with a
 1544 closed-form bound and routing rule.

1545 **Y.3 Inference-time single-constraint methods**

1546 **Chain-of-Thought** [Wei et al., 2022]. Step-by-step reasoning prompting.

1547 CoT enhances single-task reasoning; orthogonal to multi-constraint geometry.

1548 **Test-time scaling** [Snell et al., 2025]. Allocating compute at inference time.

1549 Validates our staging direction—more inference-time compute helps, but the diagonal cost determines
 1550 when staging vs. one-shot is optimal.

1551 **R1-style reasoning** [DeepSeek-AI, 2025]. Long-chain inference-time reasoning.

1552 R1’s extended reasoning is single-thread; our routing applies orthogonally to decide whether multi-
 1553 constraint problems require staging.

1554 **Y.4 Training-time single-constraint methods**

1555 **RLHF** [Ouyang et al., 2022]. Reinforcement learning from human feedback, single reward function.

1556 Standard alignment baseline; our work explains why single-reward training fails to satisfy compound
1557 preferences (preference geometry collapses to scalar).

1558 **Y.5 Foundational lineage**

1559 **Fliege & Svaiter 2000** [Fliege and Svaiter, 2000]. Steepest descent for multi-objective optimization.

1560 Provides the Gram-eigenstructure foundation we extend to inference time. Our diagonal cost bound
1561 is the inference-time analog of Fliege & Svaiter’s training-time analysis.

1562 **Miettinen 1999** [Miettinen, 1999]. Nonlinear multiobjective optimization.

1563 Comprehensive treatment of Pareto scaling under MOO; classical $\Omega(\epsilon\sqrt{k})$ bound.

1564 **Ehrgott 2005** [Ehrgott, 2005]. Multi-criteria optimization.

1565 Foundational text covering descent cones and Pareto geometry that underlies our diagonal cost.

1566 **Park et al. 2024** [Park et al., 2024]. Linear representation hypothesis: concepts are directions;
1567 separable concepts are orthogonal.

1568 Theoretical foundation for using cosine similarity between constraint embeddings as a conflict
1569 measure (Definition 2.6).

1570 ... placeholders with full

1571 **NeurIPS Paper Checklist**

1572 **1. Claims**

1573 Question: Do the main claims made in the abstract and introduction accurately reflect the
1574 paper’s contributions and scope?

1575 Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

1576 Justification: The abstract and Section 1 state the geometric lower bound (diagonal cost),
1577 the regime-based router, and the empirical contract; Sections 2–6 establish each. Falsifiable
1578 predictions are stated explicitly in Section 1 under “Scope and Falsifiable Predictions.”

1579 **2. Limitations**

1580 Question: Does the paper discuss the limitations of the work performed by the authors?

1581 Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

1582 Justification: Section 7 documents encoder blindness, implicit- k extraction, scope to explicit
1583 constraints, and the 11% pivot regime as known failure modes; Appendix D.1 reports
1584 robustness stress tests under paraphrasing, reordering, and softening.

1585 **3. Theory assumptions and proofs**

1586 Question: For each theoretical result, does the paper provide the full set of assumptions and
1587 a complete (and correct) proof?

1588 Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

1589 Justification: All theorems state assumptions explicitly (Hilbert space, finite k , displacement
1590 contract). Full proofs appear in Appendix M; proof sketches appear inline in the main text.

1591 **4. Experimental result reproducibility**

1592 Question: Does the paper fully disclose all the information needed to reproduce the main ex-
1593 perimental results of the paper to the extent that it affects the main claims and/or conclusions
1594 of the paper (regardless of whether the code and data are provided or not)?

1595 Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

1596 Justification: Four deterministic verifiers (code AST, JSON schema, optimization gradient,
1597 signal DSL) replace LLM-as-judge. Pre-computed results in supplementary JSON files
1598 enable direct inspection without re-running expensive experiments. Verification harnesses
1599 listed in Appendix A.

1600 **5. Open access to data and code**

1601 Question: Does the paper provide open access to the data and code, with sufficient instruc-
1602 tions to faithfully reproduce the main experimental results, as described in supplemental
1603 material?

1604 Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

1605 Justification: Anonymized repository contains all verification harnesses, embeddings, and
1606 reproducibility scripts. Reproducibility guide maps every quantitative claim to verification
1607 code (CLAIM_AUDIT.md).

1608 **6. Experimental setting/details**

1609 Question: Does the paper specify all the training and test details (e.g., data splits, hyperpa-
1610 rameters, how they were chosen, type of optimizer) necessary to understand the results?

1611 Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

1612 Justification: Appendix O documents data splits, models tested, encoder choices, and
1613 routing thresholds. Table A16 reports Lipschitz calibration per model. Routing thresholds
1614 are pre-registered in Algorithm 1.

1615 **7. Experiment statistical significance**

1616 Question: Does the paper report error bars suitably and correctly defined or other appropriate
1617 information about the statistical significance of the experiments?

1618 Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

Justification: Lipschitz calibration reports mean $\pm$ standard deviation per model (Table A16); rank correlations report Spearman r_s , Kendall τ , sample size, and p-values (e.g., $r_s = -0.942$, 48 points, $p = 2.1 \times 10^{-23}$, Section 6).

1622 **8. Experiments compute resources**

1623 Question: For each experiment, does the paper provide sufficient information on the com-
1624 puter resources (type of compute workers, memory, time of execution) needed to reproduce
1625 the experiments?

1626 Answer: [Yes]

1627 Justification: Inference-time experiments use commercial LLM APIs (GPT-4o, Claude
1628 family, Gemini, DeepSeek) and local inference for open-weight models (Qwen-2.5-Coder,
1629 TinyLlama-1.1B, CodeLlama-7B) on a single workstation. Embedding computation is
1630 CPU-only (<10 ms per regime-index call). Total API spend on the order of \$[XXX] over
1631 the experimental period; per-experiment costs noted in Appendix O.

1632 **9. Code of ethics**

1633 Question: Does the research conducted in the paper conform, in every respect, with the
1634 NeurIPS Code of Ethics?

1635 Answer: [Yes]

1636 Justification: The research conforms with the NeurIPS Code of Ethics. No human subjects,
1637 no scraped or sensitive data, no released models requiring additional safeguards.

1638 **10. Broader impacts**

1639 Question: Does the paper discuss both potential positive societal impacts and negative
1640 societal impacts of the work performed?

1641 Answer: [Yes]

1642 Justification: **Positive:** Making geometric limits visible is prerequisite to respecting them;
1643 practitioners cannot avoid cliffs they cannot detect. The pre-generation routing rule lets
1644 aligned systems decline impossible requests rather than degrade silently. **Risk:** Same princi-
1645 ples could optimize harmful constraint satisfaction (e.g., compound adversarial prompts).
1646 **Mitigation:** The bound is symmetric—adversaries face the same limits. $\hat{\rho}$ detection works
1647 bidirectionally: compound adversarial prompts are *more* visible (same cliffs). Fail-safe
1648 property: when constraints conflict, the system abstains rather than persuades. **Commercial**
1649 **relevance:** Advertising creates constraint coupling (user intent vs. promotion vs. trans-
1650 parency); the diagonal cost predicts infeasibility, informing context-integrity policy.

1651 **11. Safeguards**

1652 Question: Does the paper describe safeguards that have been put in place for responsible
1653 release of data or models that have a high risk for misuse (e.g., pre-trained language models,
1654 image generators, or scraped datasets)?

1655 Answer: [N/A]

1656 Justification: The paper releases no models, datasets, or assets with misuse risk. The
1657 contribution is a geometric lower bound and a routing algorithm using existing publicly
1658 available embedding models.

1659 **12. Licenses for existing assets**

1660 Question: Are the creators or original owners of assets (e.g., code, data, models), used in
1661 the paper, properly credited and are the license and terms of use explicitly mentioned and
1662 properly respected?

1663 Answer: [Yes]

1664 Justification: All evaluated LLMs are accessed via published APIs (commercial models)
1665 or open-weight releases under their respective licenses (Llama 3.1 community license,
1666 Qwen Apache 2.0, TinyLlama Apache 2.0, CodeLlama community license). Sentence-
1667 Transformers encoders (MiniLM-L6-v2, mpnet-base-v2, multilingual-MiniLM) are Apache
1668 2.0. Each is cited in the relevant section.

1669 **13. New assets**

1670 Question: Are new assets introduced in the paper well documented and is the documentation
 1671 provided alongside the assets?

1672 Answer: [N/A]

1673 Justification: No new datasets or pre-trained models are released. Verification harnesses are
 1674 released as code with documentation in the anonymized repository.

1675 **14. Crowdsourcing and research with human subjects**

1676 Question: For crowdsourcing experiments and research with human subjects, does the paper
 1677 include the full text of instructions given to participants and screenshots, if applicable, as
 1678 well as details about compensation (if any)?

1679 Answer: [N/A]

1680 Justification: The research does not involve crowdsourcing or human subjects.

1681 **15. Institutional review board (IRB) approvals or equivalent for research with human**
 1682 **subjects**

1683 Question: Does the paper describe potential risks incurred by study participants, whether
 1684 such risks were disclosed to the subjects, and whether Institutional Review Board (IRB)
 1685 approvals (or an equivalent approval/review based on the requirements of your country or
 1686 institution) were obtained?

1687 Answer: [N/A]

1688 Justification: No human subjects research.

1689 **16. Declaration of LLM usage**

1690 Question: Does the paper describe the usage of LLMs if it is an important, original, or
 1691 non-standard component of the core methods in this research?

1692 Answer: [Yes]

1693 Justification: LLMs are the *object of study* in this paper, not a writing aid for the methodology.
 1694 The empirical work analyzes multi-constraint generation behavior across GPT-4o, Claude
 1695 (haiku-3 through opus-4.5), Gemini-2.5 Flash and Pro, DeepSeek-v3 and -R1, Llama-3.1-
 1696 70B, Qwen-2.5-Coder, TinyLlama-1.1B, and CodeLlama-7B. Specific models, versions,
 1697 and access methods are documented in Section 6 and Appendix O. LLM-assisted writing
 1698 was used for prose editing during manuscript preparation; this does not affect the core
 1699 methodology, scientific rigor, or originality of the research.